

SPAN 426: INTRODUCTION TO MEXICAN AMERICAN LITERATURE



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SPAN 426: Introduction to Mexican American
Literature

Rebecca Estes

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6.1: Introduction to Chicano Literature- Mexican-American Narrative

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6.2: Historical Antecedents

In this section we will look at some elements of the historical contexts that informs Mexican-American narrative. This course will have a primary focus on 20th century Mexican-American literature, but it will be important to first begin with the Pre-hispanic literary traditions, because of the importance of indigenous roots and cultural symbols in Chicano literature. We will then take a look at some of the major literary movements and tendencies in 20th century Hispanic-American literature to locate Mexican-American narrative within a larger historical and literary context.

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6.3: Literatura prehispánica

(Translated from Spanish)

Introduction

When Europeans arrived in the Americas, they found various ways of preserving knowledge among the continent's peoples. Knowledge and historical events were transmitted through oral tradition, symbolic drawings or hieroglyphs, and colored knots or quipus. These forms of knowledge transmission were displaced with the introduction of the Latin alphabet. In the following decades, religious figures and humanists began to instruct a select group of Native Americans in the Spanish language and culture. At the same time, the catechizing friars dedicated themselves to studying the various native languages and published the first dictionaries to facilitate the catechization and Hispanization of the American population. Written versions, using the Latin alphabet, of narratives and poems in Maya-Quiché, Nahuatl, and Quechua are products of these efforts. The influence of pre-Columbian literature on such distinguished writers as Octavio Paz, Pablo Neruda, Miguel Ángel Asturias, Carlos Fuentes, Ernesto Cardenal, Gustavo Sainz, Rosario Castellanos, José María Arguedas, and Augusto Roa Bastos, among others, indicates the profound impact that pre-Hispanic works have had on contemporary Latin American literature. Currently, thanks to the work of researchers of the pre-Columbian world (Ángel María Garibay and Miguel León Portilla in the Nahuatl region; Jesús Lara and Edmundo Bendezú in the Quechua region; and Adrián Recinos, Demetrio Sodi, and León Portilla in the Mayan region), it is possible not only to understand the ideological and cultural aspects of pre-Hispanic peoples but also to appreciate their rich literature, whose beauty and uniqueness have enriched contemporary Latin American literature.

Nahuatl literature

Although commonly classified under the genre of Aztec literature, Nahuatl literature encompasses not only the Aztecs who inhabited the city of Tenochtitlan, Mexico, but also the many peoples who comprised this empire and who maintained the Nahuatl language as a common denominator. The *Nahuatl* word means "clear" or "luminous." These qualities are especially evident in their poetry, considered the most sublime of their artistic expressions. Through poetry, the Nahua people sought to communicate with their deities; therefore, it was an activity performed with great solemnity by nobles and rulers. Nahuatl poetry was often accompanied by music, which explains why the Nahuatl equivalent of the word for poetry is "inxóchitl," meaning "flower and song." The experience of listening to poetic words—metaphorically described as "the flowers of the Giver of Life"—took place in special rooms of princes and kings or in royal gardens. The listeners were part of an *icniuhyotl*, a kind of brotherhood gathered around poetry.

Because poetry was one of the most valued arts among the ancient Mexicans, there are multiple branches of this genre. Among the most prominent are:

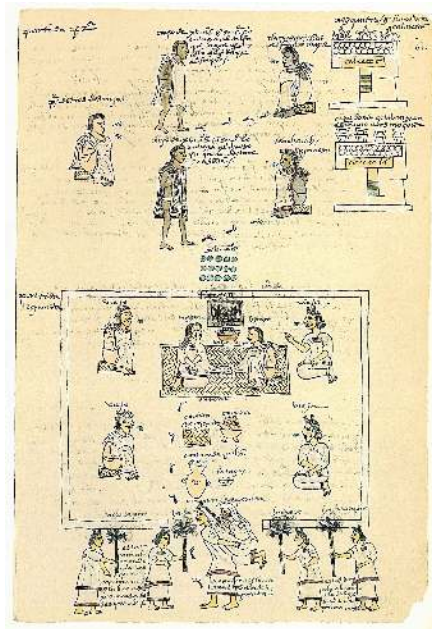
Yaocuícatl, war songs dedicated to extolling the warlike feats of a people.

Teocuícatl, songs to the gods glorifying the importance of the various deities that made up the religion of the ancient Mexicans. They also narrate the origins of humanity. One of the most representative examples is the myth known as "The Five Suns," which recounts the five cosmic periods of the Earth.

Xoxxiuícatl, songs that frequently allude to flowers. Flowers are a symbol of great importance to the literary expression of the Nahua peoples. The use of flowers in poetry serves as a metaphor for works of divine origin; sometimes flowers also appear as a metaphor for battles in war songs.

Incocuícatl, sad and philosophical songs that express the innermost aspects of the soul. The greatest representatives of this tradition are the ruler of the people of Texcoco, the poet-king Netzahualcōyotl (1402-1472), Moctezuma, the Aztec ruler at the time of the conquest, and Macuixochitl, one of the few Nahua poets, born in 1435 and daughter of the famous warrior Tlacaélel. This poetic genre was also used in the songs that describe the tragic fall of the Aztec capital, Tenochtitlán. It is at this time (1521) that the painful subjugation of the indigenous people to Spanish culture begins.

These four branches of Nahuatl poetry are not the only ones; new subdivisions have been discovered, such as cosmogonic songs, songs to animals, songs to spring, mischievous songs, etc. However, these four branches are the main and most representative.



Calemac, del Códice Mendoza

Poetry was taught in the *Calmecac*, schools for the ruling class, and also in educational centers dedicated exclusively to teaching songs, called *Cuicalli*. Nahuatl poetry abounds in *parallelism* (repetition of the same idea throughout a stanza or paragraph), *difrasismo* (the combination of two complementary concepts to express the same idea), particular symbols and imagery, emphasis on certain words and phrases, as well as the use of metaphors and similes. All these stylistic devices characterize the speech and expression of the ancient Mexicans.

Specialist Birgitta Leander has compiled a list of *difrasismos* found in Nahuatl poetic expression, making their meanings more comprehensible to the reader. She highlights, for example, that to express the idea of beauty, the concepts of "jade and fine feathers" were combined, objects highly valued by Mexican nobles; to express the idea of woman, the words "skirt and blouse" were added; the idea of a person was conveyed by combining the words "face and heart," and so on. In this way, artistic expression was achieved through allusions, resulting in a high degree of metaphorical language in poetic language. The *Yaocuicatl*, or war song, provides a good example of parallelism. The first two lines, "from where the eagles perch/from where the tigers stand tall," create, through two parallel phrases, the idea of war, since the most prominent militia groups were the Eagle Knights and the Tiger Knights; naming them established a clear, always parallel, allusion to war. Regarding the versification of Nahuatl poetry, James Lockhart and Frances Karttunen state that Nahua verses are "units of expression." That is, the verses are not constructed based on a linear structure that progresses rigidly and orderly from verse to verse, but rather the verses can be arranged and rearranged in different parts of the poem because they are independent. The verses are related by belonging to the same central theme; therefore, linear ordering is not necessary.

Huehuetlahtolli, or the prose of the elders, who were considered the keepers of wisdom and knowledge. In these texts, we find speeches where parents advise their children on how to lead a dignified life, as well as the responses that young people give to their parents or grandparents in gratitude for their advice. This prose also reveals descriptions of what a *tlamatini* (a wise person) or a *temachtiani* (a teacher) should be. Miguel León Portilla, the foremost researcher of the Nahuatl world, has identified the main categories of *huehuetlahtolli*, highlighting five basic variants. Finally, the *tlahtolli* are documents that showcase both the literary language of the ancient Nahua people and their beliefs and philosophies. Thanks to the impressive work of Fray Bernardino de Sahagún [1], who dedicated himself to the study of the Nahuatl world for seventy years, we now possess examples of a literary expression that enriches the current landscape of Mexican literature.

Mayan literature

The literature of the Maya-Quiché peoples that we know today includes three fundamental works:

- 1) The Books of *Chilam Balam*, which, according to Miguel León Portilla, number eighteen, of which only three have been studied in depth: the *Chilam Balam of Chumayel*, the *Chilam Balam of Tizimín*, and the *Chilam Balam of Maní*. These

books were written by the *chilamoob* —high-ranking Mayan priests in the Yucatán region—and symbolically recreate mythological events and compile religious, historical, literary, and astronomical knowledge from various periods. Their stories also have a prophetic character, as is the case with the legend of Vucub-Caquix, which narrates the arrival of the *dzules* , that is, the Spanish foreigners.

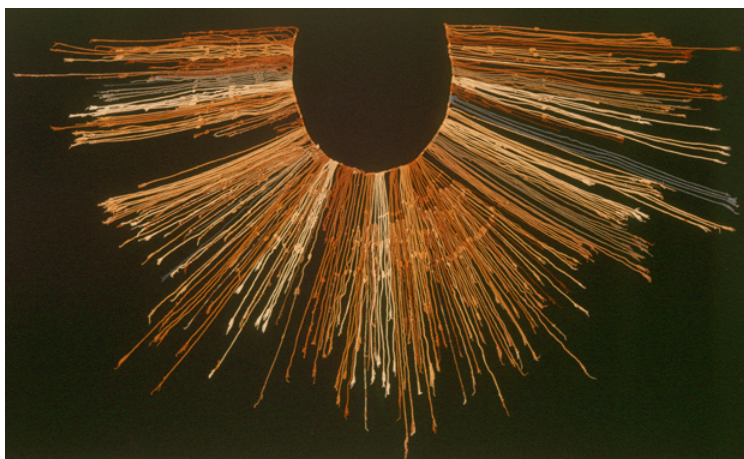


Plato Blom. Representación de escena del Popol Vuh

- 2) The *Book of the Council* , or *Popol Vuh*, named after a priest who lived shortly before the conquest and predicted the arrival of the Europeans, is the most representative literary text of pre-Hispanic literatures due to its widespread dissemination throughout the world. This book was transcribed after the massacre ordered by the Spanish conquistador Pedro de Alvarado in a region of Guatemala. Witnessing such bloody destruction, the priests of the area set out to transcribe their stories into the Latin alphabet, fearing the destruction of their codices (collections of documents) by the conquistadors. The *Popol Vuh* is divided into three parts. The first part recounts the creation of the world and the various attempts by the gods to create humankind. The second part narrates the war between the true gods and the false gods. The third part describes the various migrations and genealogies of the Quiché people. Since they possessed a cyclical conception of the universe in which the stars and time were considered deities, it can be assumed that their scientific interest arose from the need to better understand these deities in order to facilitate earthly life.
- 3) The play *Rabinal-Achí* narrates the fight between two warriors: Rabinal Achí and Quiché Achí. Rabinal wins the battle and leads his opponent before the king, Rabinal's father. The characters begin to argue, and the drama ends with the death of Quiché Achí. This lengthy play abounds in parallelism, polite expressions, and repetitions characteristic of pre-Columbian speech. However, due to the complexity of its writing, it has not been fully deciphered.

Quechua literature

Quechua literature, or *Runasimi* , the language of the Incas and the peoples under their dominion, presents a significant obstacle: the lack of a pictographic or ideographic writing system. The only known system of signs consists of quipus: cords with colored knots arranged in such a way that information could be stored through their arrangement and colors.



Quipu inca del Museo Larco (Lima)

Researchers have not yet been able to decipher any of the quipus and postulate that they are accounting instruments, due to the decimal arrangement of their knots. Consequently, no known documents remain that allow for in-depth study of their literature; therefore, it is necessary to rely on other sources to recover their humanistic contributions. The only existing accounts belong to the colonial period and come from chroniclers. Among the main chroniclers are: Cieza de León, Guamán Poma, Cristóbal de Molina, Blas Valera, Juan de Santa Cruz Pachakuti, and Inca Garcilaso de la Vega. In contemporary times, the prominent Bolivian anthropologist Jesús Lara spurred the investigation of the literary evidence contained in the various chronicles. Lara also maintained that the quipus actually comprise a language that has not yet been deciphered but that contains historical, geographical, literary, astronomical, legal, and economic knowledge of Inca society.

From the information gleaned from colonial texts, it is possible to observe some parallels with the organization of the Nahua world. The Incas, like the Nahua people of the central valley of Mexico, placed great importance on poetry; their songs were present in funeral ceremonies, agricultural work, and official celebrations. Just as the Nahua had elders and wise men, or *tlamatinimes*, who transmitted philosophical and religious knowledge, the Incas had *amautas*, historians and philosophers who disseminated knowledge and were in charge of dramatic performances. Since the *amautas* were part of the imperial retinue, they created compositions to celebrate military victories, the ascension to the throne of the new Inca, the most important events of his reign, as well as religious hymns to venerate the rulers and their deities. Alongside them were the *haravicus*, or “poetry inventors,” who often recited their verses accompanied by the audience. Another interesting parallel between the Incas and the ancient Mexicans can be seen in the education of the elite. Just as nobles in the Nahua world attended the *Calmecac*, Inca nobles attended the *Yachayhuasi*, where they received a literary education. However, despite their similarities, there is a fundamental difference between these two pre-Hispanic cultural organizations. Jesús Lara points out that poetry was not, for the Quechua, the exclusive domain of the nobility, as it was in the case of the ancient Mexicans, but could be studied and composed by members of the lower strata of the Inca social structure.

Regarding his poetry, the following classification can be established:

Jailli were triumphal songs sung to glorify the gods, with Viracoch being the principal deity. The second classification of *jailli* comprises heroic songs that extolled war and the valor of battles. The third classification refers to the agricultural song variant, which was sung to celebrate sowing and harvesting.

Wawaki are songs in the form of a dialogue, sung by a male and a female chorus that alternate throughout the composition. Jesús Lara mentions that *wawaki* were sung during festivities in honor of the moon.

Arawi, songs that refer to intimate life—love, loneliness, sadness—and imprisonment. A representative work of this genre is the dramatic work known as *Ollantay*, a play that continues to be performed in Andean villages today. Although its indigenous authenticity is questioned, it may be a dramatic adaptation of a legend that circulated orally among the Quechua people.

Wayñu, this genre of poetry was accompanied by a musical and dance troupe and was of a collective nature.

In contrast to the poetry of ancient Mexico, the few surviving examples of Inca poetry are primarily religious in nature. The most abundant and varied compositions of Inca culture are found in the *Primer nueva crónica y buen gobierno* (*First New Chronicle and Good Government*) by the Andean chronicler Guamán Poma. Likewise, Inca Garcilaso de la Vega dedicated a chapter of his *Comentarios Reales* (Royal Commentaries) to describing Inca poetry (Book 11, Chapter XXVII).

The literary expressions of pre-Hispanic cultures capture the pride of their peoples, their diverse epistemologies, and express their aspirations for a better future. Their narratives reaffirm the resilience of Indigenous peoples and the cultural and linguistic heterogeneity of the Latin American continent. Natalio Hernández Xocoyotzin, a bilingual poet in Nahuatl and Spanish, has expressed the dynamic between pre-Hispanic and Spanish heritage. He compares Spanish to the ahuehuete tree, which provides shelter and shade. This tree, that is, Spanish, is nourished by the Indigenous languages that give Latin American Spanish its distinctive characteristics. His literature reaffirms the resilience of diverse Indigenous groups and the cultural plurality of their peoples.

Activities on the introduction

Vocabulary in context

After reading the introduction, define the following terms in English and in your own words:

- Quipus:
- Native Americans:
- Catechist friars:
- Pre-Columbian/Pre-Hispanic Literature:
- Nahuatl:
- Inxóchtli:
- Parallelisms (include an example different from those in the text):
- Difrasismos (include an example different from those in the text):
- Codices (do an internet search to expand on the definition given in the text and include some examples of codices):
- Quechua:
- Calmecac and School:
- Tlamatinime:
- Pictographic or ideographic writing:

General comprehension questions

- 1) Why can indigenous testimonies be considered colonial documents? Who was involved in their collection during the first decades of the colony and for what purpose did they do so?
- 2) What were some ways of preserving knowledge in indigenous cultures?
- 3) What is the importance of pre-Hispanic literatures in the contemporary world?
- 4) What function did poetry have in the area of ancient Mexico? Explain its content.
- 5) What are the characteristics of the metaphorical language of Nahuatl poetry?
- 6) Who were the **amautas** and the **haravicus** and how are they related to the development of indigenous poetry?
- 7) What do you understand by “cultural heterogeneity” and what role do indigenous literatures play in defining this concept?

Primary texts

Reading: Nahuatl Literature

The flowers and the songs [2]

Xochicuícatl

Version by Miguel León Portilla

From within the sky they come

The beautiful flowers, the beautiful songs. [3]

Our longing makes them ugly,

Our inventiveness spoils them, [4]

except for those of the Chichimec prince Tecayehuatzin.

Rejoice with his people!

Friendship is a shower of precious flowers.

White tufts [5] of heron feathers,

They are intertwined with beautiful red flowers:
on the branches of the trees,
They walk and drink beneath them
the lords and the nobles.
Your beautiful song:
A golden rattlesnake, you raise it up so beautifully. [6]
You are in a flower enclosure.
You sing on the flowering branches.
Are you perhaps a precious bird of the Giver of Life?
Have you spoken to God?
As soon as you saw the dawn,
You started to sing.
Strive, my heart desires,
the flowers on the shield,
the flowers of the Giver of Life.
What can my heart do?
We have come here in vain,
we have sprouted from the earth.
Is this the only way I have to leave?
like the flowers that perished?
Will nothing remain of my name? [7]
None of my fame here on earth?
At least flowers, at least songs!
What can my heart do?
We have come here in vain,
we have sprouted from the earth.
Let us rejoice, oh friends,
There will be hugs here.
Now we walk on the flowery land.
Nobody will end this here
the flowers and the songs
They endure in the house of the Giver of life.
Here on earth is the region of the fleeting moment.
Is it also like that in the place
where one somehow lives?
Is one happy there?
Is there friendship there?

Or only here on Earth

Have we come here to see our faces?

Reflection and analysis questions

- 1) Comment on the emotional and philosophical attitude that is derived from this poem.
- 2) Explain the importance of the repeated image of flowers in Nahuatl poetry.
- 3) What is the concept of fame? And according to the poem, what is the only thing that should endure on earth?
- 4) How is nature described and what does it tell us about the relationship of the ancient Mexicans and their environment?



Excavación en El Mirador, Petén, Guatemala – El panel representa otra escena del Popol Vuh

Reading: Mayan Literature

From Popol Vuh

The legend of Vucub-Caquix [8]

Translation by Adrián Recinos

There was then very little light on the face of the earth. There was still no sun. However, there was a being proud of himself who was called Vucub-Caquix. [9] The sky and the earth already existed, but the face of the sun and the moon was hidden. And he (Vucub-Caquix) said: [10] -Truly, they are a clear example of those men who drowned, and their nature is like that of supernatural beings.

"I will now be great above all created and formed beings. I am the sun, I am the light, the moon," he exclaimed. "Great is my splendor. Through me, men will walk and conquer. For my eyes are silver, resplendent like precious stones, like emeralds; my teeth

gleam like fine stones, like the face of the sky. My nose shines from afar like the moon, my throne is silver, and the face of the earth is illuminated when I appear before my throne."

Thus, I am the sun, I am the moon, for the human race. So it shall be, for my sight reaches far.

This is how Vucub-Caquix spoke. But in truth, Vucub-Caquix was not the sun; he only boasted of his feathers and riches. But his vision reached only the horizon and did not extend over the whole world.

The face of the sun, the moon, and the stars was not yet visible, and dawn had not yet broken. For this reason, Vucub-Caquix boasted as if he were the sun and the moon, because the light of the sun and the moon had not yet appeared or been displayed. His only ambition was to aggrandize himself and dominate. And it was then that the flood occurred because of the wooden figures. [11]

Now we will tell how Vucub Caquix died and was defeated, and how man was made by the Creator and Former.

This is the beginning of the defeat and ruin of Vucub Caquix's glory at the hands of the two boys, the first of whom was named Hunahpú [12] and the second Ixbalanqué. These were truly gods. Seeing the evil that the proud one was doing, and that he wanted to do it in the presence of the Heart of Heaven, the boys said to one another

"It is not right that things should be this way, when man does not yet live here on earth. So, we will try shooting him with the blowgun while he is eating; we will shoot him and cause him to have a disease, and then his riches, his green stones, his precious metals, his emeralds, his jewels of which he is so proud will be gone. And so all men will do, for they should not become vain because of power or wealth."

"That's how it will be," said the boys, each slinging his blowgun over his shoulder.

Reflection and analysis questions

- 1) What does "The Legend of Vucub-Caquix" tell? What is its moral or lesson?
- 2) Explain the need that all cultures express to create their own mythology.
- 3) Are there any similarities between the myths in your culture and the indigenous myths described in the reading?



Ejemplar del Libro de Chilam Balam de Chumayel en el Museo de Antropología de México.

From the Books of Chilam Balam of Chumayel

The Dzules [13]

Translation by Demetrio Sodi

This is what I write: In 1541 was the first arrival of the Dzules, the foreigners, from the East. They came to Ecab, that is its name. And it happened that they came to the Water Gate, to Ecab, to the town of Nacom Balam, in the beginning of the days of the years of the eleventh katun. [14] Fifteen twenty-year periods [15] before the arrival of the Dzules, the Itzáes [16] dispersed. The town of Zaciahtun was abandoned, the town of Kinchil Coba was abandoned, Chichén Itzá was abandoned, Uxmal was abandoned, and south of Uxmal, Kabah, that is its name, was abandoned. Zeye, Pakam, Homtun, the town of Tixcalomkin, and Ake, the one with the stone gates, were abandoned. [17]

The town where the rain falls, Etzamal, was abandoned, there where the son of the All-God descended, the lord of heaven, the lord-lady, the miraculous virgin. [18] And the lord said: "Lower the shields of Kinich Kakmo." One can no longer reign here. But the Miraculous One, the Merciful One, remains. "Lower the ropes, lower the belts fallen from heaven. Lower the word fallen from heaven." And thus the other peoples paid homage to his lordship; thus it was said that the lord-gods of Etzamal were of no use.

And then the great Itzáes departed. Thirteen times four hundred times four hundred thousand and fifteen times four hundred times four hundred hundreds the Itzáes lived as heretics. [19] But they departed and with them their disciples, who sustained them and who were very numerous. Thirteen measures was Iximal and the head of the count of those of Iximal there were nine almudes and three oc. [20] And the children of the people went with their gods before and behind.

Their spirits rejected the Dzules and their Christianity. They offered no tribute, neither the spirits of the birds, nor the precious stones, nor the carved stones, nor the tigers that protected them. Sixteen hundred and three hundred years, and their lives would end. They knew how to measure time, even within themselves. The moon, the wind, the year, the day: everything moves, but also passes. All blood reaches its resting place, just as all power reaches its throne. The time was measured when the greatness of the Three would be praised. [21] Measured was the time of the sun's goodness, of the lattice formed by the stars, from where the gods contemplate us. The good lords of the stars, all of them good. [22]

They possessed wisdom, holiness; there was no evil in them. There was health, devotion; there was no sickness, no bone pain, no fever or smallpox, no chest or stomach pain. [23] They walked upright. But the Dzules came and destroyed everything. They taught fear, withered the flowers, sucked the lifeblood out of others so that their own might live. They killed the flower of the Nac-xit Xuchit. There were no longer any priests to teach us. And so the second era settled, began to reign, and was the cause of our death. Without priests, without wisdom, without courage, and without shame, all were equal. There was no great wisdom, no word, no teaching from the lords. The gods who came here were of no use. The Dzules had come only to castrate the Sun! And their children's children remained among us, receiving only their bitterness.

Reflection and analysis questions

- 1) What does the Mayan legend of "The dzules" tell us?
- 2) What historical and literary importance does the fragment of "Los dzules" have?
- 3) What feelings emerge from this passage? What was the Mayan view of the Spanish?
- 4) How are the Spanish and Mayan cultures contrasted in the legend?
- 5) Discuss the literary importance of this Mayan testimony.

Reading: Quechua Literature

First prayer to the maker Jailli [24]

Version of Jesus Lara

Root of being, Viracocha,
God always near,
Lord of garments

dazzling
God who governs and preserves,
Who creates simply by saying:
"Let there be man,

"Let it be a woman."
The being you placed
and raised.

Let him live free.

And without danger.

Where are you?

Outside the world,
inside the world,

In the midst of the clouds
or in the midst of the shadows?

Listen to me,

Answer me.
Make me live.

For many days,
until the age when I must
turn gray.
Lift me up
, take me in your arms.

And in my weariness,

Help me
wherever you are,

Father Viracocha

Reflection and analysis questions

- 1) What is the role of religion in Quechua culture and how is the importance of religion manifested in the *jailli* ?
- 2) What images are used to allude to divinity?
- 3) What relationship between the person and the divinity does the poetic voice propose?
- 4) What does the poetic voice ask of the Creator? What fear does the poetic voice express?
- 5) Can you relate this *jailli* to another religious prayer?

Topics to develop

- 1) In groups of four, imagine you belong to the ancient Aztec nobility and want to write a poem to present to your friends. Choose a variant of Nahuatl poetry and, using rhetorical devices such as difrasismo, parallelism, and metaphor, write a short poem. You can choose one of the following themes: a eulogy to the gods of nature, a love song, a war song, or the experience of the fall of the great city of Tenochtitlán to Hernán Cortés's troops. Be prepared to share.
- 2) **The Role of Missionaries in Relation to Ancient American Knowledge** - Which were the most well-known religious orders that arrived in the New World? What was the purpose of these missions? What kind of religious instruction did they offer? Why the interest in studying native languages? What role did they play in preserving indigenous culture? How can the impact of these missionaries be seen in Latin American culture?
- 3) **The Impact of the Latin Alphabet on the Amerindian World** – As we know, when the Spanish arrived in America, they introduced various aspects of Western culture to the pre-Columbian cultures. One of these aspects was the introduction of the Spanish language. Considering the status given to Spanish in relation to indigenous languages, answer the following questions: What were the consequences of the contact between Spanish and indigenous languages such as Quechua in Bolivia, Guaraní in Paraguay, or Nahuatl in Mexico? How were the native cultures affected, and how is this reflected to this day? What were the advantages and disadvantages of having only ONE official language?
- 4) **Modes of Indigenous Resistance to Colonization** - Bearing in mind that acts of resistance against invasion and colonial domination can unfold in diverse ways, explore one of the methods and forms of Indigenous resistance from the arrival of Europeans to the American continent in the 16th century until the emancipation of the colonies in the 18th century. You can choose one of the following topics: Military tactics (rebellions), cultural resistance (syncretism of religion/language/traditions), use of legal systems (such as appeals in the courts), writing of chronicles and accounts (Felipe Guamán Poma, Inca Garcilaso de la Vega, Fernando de Alva Ixtlilxóchitl, Hernando de Alvarado Tezozómoc, etc.).
- 5) **Function and Importance of Indigenous Myths** - All cultures throughout history have developed a worldview based on myths. Explore their importance in the creation of a cultural identity. You can use these questions as a guide: What is a myth? Who invents them and for whom? How were they transmitted and preserved? What is their purpose? What are their teachings? Is there an aspect

that is consistently repeated in different myths? What is their cultural value? Are there any myths in your culture that resemble any indigenous myths? Why is it important to learn about them? What is their significance in indigenous cultures and identities today?

1. [Friar Bernardino de Sahagún \(Sahagún, Spain, 1499 or 1500 – Mexico, 1590\)](#) was a catechist of the Franciscan Order. In 1529, he traveled to Mexico and there worked on the conversion of the indigenous Mexicans. He learned the Nahuatl language and researched Mayan culture and beliefs. He translated his research into Spanish and wrote his fundamental work: *General History of the Things of New Spain*. This text contains twelve volumes and narrates aspects of Mayan culture such as their gods, their festivals, their beliefs about the immortality of the soul, their astrological knowledge, and their intellectual and political life. It also contains a dictionary of the Nahuatl language and recounts the conquest of Mexico from the indigenous perspective.
2. [The poem belongs to the text Dialogue of the Flower and the Song](#) and is part of the manuscript *Mexican Songs*, folio 14. Its author is Prince Tecayehuatzin.
3. “The beautiful flowers, the beautiful songs” is the most frequently repeated metaphor in Nahuatl poetry .
4. The poet’s limited literary skill is what detracts from the beauty of the songs, which are intrinsically beautiful. The poet displays a position of humility before such magnificent art .
5. designates friendship ↵
6. The poet describes poetic song as a golden rattlesnake. Note the high esteem the ancient Mexicans placed on the beauty of birds .
7. [This philosophical question echoes the concerns expressed by other Nahua poets in their poetry. The answer exemplifies the position of poetry in the Nahua world: if everything else](#) must disappear, at least let the songs survive.
8. Passage from the *Popol Vuh*, a book containing narratives of the Maya-Quiché people collected by Father Francisco Ximénez. This Andalusian priest arrived in Guatemala in 1688 and was appointed parish priest of Chichicastenango, a region of Guatemala. It was during this time that he discovered the manuscript written in Latin characters known as the *Chichicastenango Manuscript*, which contained the text of the *Popol Vuh*. Ximénez translated it into Spanish and dedicated himself to recovering the histories of the Maya people. This passage narrates the struggle between the true gods and the false gods .
9. The name Vucub-Caquix has been translated by Adrián Recinos as “Seven Macaws”, while Miguel Ángel Asturias translates it as “Main Macaw” .
10. [Vucub-Caquix, who is admiring the monkeys, is alluding to the flood narrated earlier. In this flood, human beings were transformed into monkeys by the gods. Vucub-Caquix, being the only man to survive the flood who was](#) not turned into a monkey, becomes arrogant and proclaims himself a god.
11. The stick figures: the human beings created by the gods before the flood. These beings were exterminated for not praising the gods. In Mayan mythology, there were several attempts by the gods to create true human beings .
12. Hunahpú is translated as “Master Magician” and Ixbalanqué as “Wizard” ↵
13. This fragment comes from the *Chilam Balam of Chuyamel*, one of the eighteen versions or books of *Chilam Balam* known to this day. These books were written after the Spanish Conquest and narrate the beliefs, mythologies, and genealogies of the Maya-Quiché people. *Chilam* is the Maya name the community gave to priests, and *balam* means sorcerer and also jaguar. *Chuyamel* is the name of the Yucatecan region where the manuscript originates, a facsimile edition of which was published in 1913 .
14. [Date given in Mayan numerals. The katun refers to a 20-year cycle that recurs in 160-year periods](#) ; the sign “eleven ahau” is a period of years ruled by hardship. The date “katun eleven ahau” pinpoints the moment when Spanish rule was firmly established in Yucatán (1541).
15. The Mayan numerical system was vigesimal; the number mentioned (1241) refers to the time when the Maya abandoned their main cities. Many theories explain this abandonment by religious, historical, political, and/or agricultural causes; however, the definitive cause for the abandonment of the main Mayan cities is still unknown .
16. Maya who refused to accept the Christianity brought by colonization. They lived independently until 1697, when they were subjected to Spanish rule .

17. A detailed description of the towns and ceremonial centers abandoned by the Maya before the arrival of the Spanish .
18. [The Lord of the Sky](#) exhibits the feminine-masculine duality characteristic of the supreme Mayan and Nahua gods.
19. The complex figure is meant to express that the Itzaes decided categorically not to accept any religion other than their own. Above all, they rejected, as far as possible, the Christian religion .
20. old measure that approximates five liters ↵
21. Reference to the deity known as the Heart of Heaven, who, in the Popol Vuh passage, is the one who determines Vucub-Caquix's punishment. This deity possessed a triptych configuration: Caculhá-Huaracán, Chipi-Caculhá, and Raxa-Caculhá .
22. This elegy to the Mayan gods reveals the grief of the ancient Mexicans at the extinction of their culture .
23. Smallpox did not exist among the pre-Hispanic peoples. When this disease arrived, it caused devastating epidemics and high mortality rates .
24. Poem recovered by Father Cristóbal de Molina in 1575, included in his book Fables and Rites of the Incas .

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6.4: Hispanoamérica 1930-1969



From the 1930s to the early 1970s, Latin America experienced an intense confrontation between aspirations for radical, communist-inspired social change and the maintenance of capitalist development within existing structures. The nationalist era, which until the 1950s even manifested itself in import restrictions to strengthen local industry, gave way to a "Latin Americanist" era, characterized by enthusiasm for social change and debate over which side to take during the Cold War.

The triumph of the Cuban Revolution (1959) became a touchstone for both left-wing and right-wing ideologies in the debate about the place of Latin American countries in the global power structure and what their sociopolitical model should be. Consequently, Latin American artistic and literary production received significant international attention during those years.



Mural of the Communist Youth in Havana, Cuba (1960s).
 This mural illustrates the cultural framework of "study, work and rifle" (intellectuals, workers and guerrillas) with which one part of the population aspired to generate radical changes and which another part of the population saw as a threat to stability, prosperity and security.

Nacionalismo y populismo

superar: <i>to overcome</i> lograr: <i>to attain</i> soberanía: <i>sovereignty</i> debilitarse: <i>to weaken</i> materias primas: <i>raw materials</i> terrateniente: <i>large land owner</i> a menudo: <i>often</i> ejército: <i>army</i> golpe (militar): <i>coup</i> desempleo: <i>unemployment</i> escasez: <i>scarcity</i> impuestos: <i>taxes</i> dueño: <i>owner</i> sindicato: <i>labor union</i> ventaja: <i>advantage</i> obrero: <i>industry worker</i> empresario: <i>business owner</i> receta: <i>recipe</i> hasta cierto punto: <i>to a certain extent</i> tarde o temprano: <i>sooner or later</i> peligrar: <i>to be in danger</i> amenazar: <i>to threaten</i> empresa: <i>enterprise, company</i> cada vez más: <i>ever more</i>	Following the economic expansion of the first three decades of the 20th century, the export-oriented bourgeoisie weakened with the depression experienced by global capitalism during the 1930s. International demand for agricultural products and raw materials was halved. The pendulum then swung back to the conservative right. The traditional landowning elite regained control of the government, repressing leftist activism, often with the support of the military. During the 1930s, there were military governments or attempted coups in Argentina, Uruguay, Brazil, Chile, Bolivia, Peru, Venezuela, Cuba, the Dominican Republic, Guatemala, Nicaragua, El Salvador, and Honduras. [1] The military thus recovered its influential role in Latin American politics. Related to this militarism and the economic crisis, several nationalist wars reminiscent of those of the 19th century also reappeared: Bolivia-Paraguay (1933-38); Colombia-Peru (1932-34); Peru-Ecuador (1941-42). To address unemployment and shortages of imported goods, the strategy of incentivizing domestic manufacturing became widespread through a protectionist policy known as "import substitution industrialization" (ISI). To this end, governments raised import taxes, established or financed new industries, kept wages low, and reduced taxes on domestic products. Nationalist propaganda was also promoted, along with efforts to regain domestic control of natural resources and a sense of pride in domestic products over foreign ones. Industrial owners grew wealthier and could influence politics, but labor unions also grew larger, and political parties that won their support gained an electoral advantage. Control, then, had to be negotiated primarily among three power groups: 1) the interests of the traditional landowning elite, often associated with the Church; 2) the emerging commercial and industrial bourgeoisie, with increasing economic and social influence; - and 3) the working class and the unions, whose support (or control) was crucial for continued industrial expansion. In many cases, the balance tipped in favor of the sector that secured military and/or Washington support. But in certain countries and periods, left-wing parties gained considerable influence, as in Chile during the 1950s and 60s. The different forms of government in Latin America during these decades represent diverse strategies for combining these power groups. One such formula was a pro-industrial and pro-military alliance that attempted to incorporate the interests of business owners while simultaneously satisfying some workers' demands under the magnetism of an authoritarian and charismatic leader. This was the recipe for <i>populism</i>, applied by Perón in Argentina, Vargas in Brazil, Rojas Pinilla in Colombia, and, to some extent, Arbenz in Guatemala, Velasco Ibarra in Ecuador, and Cárdenas in Mexico. The problem was that they tried to represent two emerging groups with conflicting interests (workers and their employers), one of which sooner or later felt betrayed, and these systems were unsustainable in times of economic austerity. Their stability was also jeopardized if reforms threatened the interests of landowners or North American companies. In other cases, different political parties included both emerging groups (Chile), while others excluded them through dictatorships (Venezuela, Nicaragua, Paraguay), or coalitions formed between sectors of the middle class, workers, and peasants for armed resistance (Colombia, El Salvador). In some cases, these coalitions managed to seize power and implement liberal reforms for a time, as in the 1936 revolution in Paraguay, the 1944 revolution in Guatemala, and the 1952 revolution in Bolivia. However, this type of revolution would become increasingly difficult within the context of the aggressive US policy of securing the continent's loyalty during the Cold War.
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[1] The great exception has been Costa Rica, whose party government established a progressive social security and worker protection system and, a decade later, eliminated the national army.

Cold War and left-wing activism

cuantioso: <i>quite large</i> inversión: <i>investment</i> a medida que: <i>as (process)</i> lograr: <i>to achieve</i> sede: <i>headquarters</i> doblaje: <i>dubbing</i> encubierto: <i>under cover</i> de parte de: <i>in favor of</i> derrocamiento: <i>overthrow</i> entre tanto: <i>in the meantime</i> gabinete: <i>cabinet</i> a partir de: <i>starting in</i> duradero: <i>lasting</i> así como: <i>as well as</i> ambiente: <i>climate, environment</i> ámbito: <i>sphere, field</i> Evangelio: <i>Gospel</i> a largo plazo: <i>in the long run</i>	The most significant impact of World War II on Latin America was its definitive inclusion within Washington's sphere of influence. By 1945, Western Europe had been forced to liquidate its investments in the Americas to finance the war, and its influence was considerably reduced. The United States, on the other hand, consolidated its position as a global political, economic, and military power, with substantial investments throughout the continent. As relations with the Russians cooled, the Truman administration persuaded almost all Latin American countries to sever ties with the Soviet Union and several governments to outlaw local communist parties—a move that also aligned with the interests of the economic elite. In 1948, the Organization of American States (OAS), headquartered in Washington, was established in Bogotá to promote common policies across the continent. During the following years, the Pentagon strengthened its influence over Latin American militaries, reinforcing and expanding its military bases in the region. The United States became the Hemisphere's leading trading partner. And in the cultural sphere, American television and film productions, with their efficient dubbing systems, flooded markets across the entire continent. Covert CIA interventions became commonplace, generally carried out by the elite and against popular movements. Two of these interventions—which fueled anti-American sentiment among the left—led to the overthrow of reformist President Jacobo Árbenz of Guatemala in 1954 and of Salvador Allende of Chile in 1973, despite both having been democratically elected in their respective countries. Meanwhile, popular support for communist parties grew in many Latin American countries, gaining a foothold in the Chilean cabinet and securing seats in Congress in more than nine governments during the 1940s. Armed resistance in the form of guerrilla warfare, already understandable given the high poverty rates, acquired a radical nationalist dimension from the 1950s onward: the “liberation” from U.S. imperialism and capitalist exploitation. And from the 1960s onward, the Soviet Union and China also played their part in drawing Latin America into their sphere of influence, helping to finance revolutionary guerrilla movements in the region. The enduring victory of the Cuban Revolution in 1959 served as a wake-up call for Washington and the elites, as well as a catalyst for the proliferation of “national liberation struggles” in rural and urban guerrilla movements throughout Latin America. For grassroots activists, it seemed for the first time possible that workers and peasants could seize control of the state and obtain the right to healthcare, education, and a decent standard of living. As with the student movement in France or the civil rights struggles in the United States, many Latin American students and <i>intelligentsia</i> joined the activist fervor that characterized the 1960s worldwide. The most famous intellectuals of the time depicted in their works the history of marginalization and repression of the people, as well as their aspirations for more egalitarian and participatory societies. One of the most widely disseminated books was <i>*Open Veins of Latin America*</i>, by the Uruguayan Eduardo Galeano (1940-2015), which examined the history of injustice and human exploitation on the continent. In Chile, a left-wing coalition (the “Popular Unity”) won the 1970 elections, and Salvador Allende, the new president, nationalized the copper mines that were in the hands of foreign companies, raised workers' wages, and froze the prices of basic necessities, among other socialist-style reforms. The Cuban government also launched a campaign to spread socialism throughout the Americas with substantial Soviet funding. But both failed to consolidate long-term economies that were prosperous for all.
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Latin Americanism of the 1960s

As we have seen, the triumph of the Cuban Revolution in 1959 became a driving force behind the proliferation of “liberation struggles” in rural and urban guerrilla movements throughout Central and South America. The term “Latin America,” understood as a unity of peoples with shared aspirations and a history of oppression, then served to foster the struggle for social change and for political and cultural sovereignty, particularly along leftist lines. This utopian spirit was also manifested in the conviction that, from

Mexico to the Southern Cone, these peoples shared a colonial past, a present of dependency, and a common destiny of liberation (the “Latin American identity” or “Latin Americanism”) and therefore should unite in a common struggle against two enemies: the interests of Washington in the service of Wall Street, and the local ruling class associated with those interests. Thus, the 1960s marked a period of immense creativity, enthusiastic unification, and international dissemination in the arts and intellectual production for Latin America. A large number of young people across the continent sang along to musical movements like South American protest songs and Cuban Nueva Trova, sympathized with leftist groups in their countries, and participated in avant-garde poetry movements. They read with admiration novels that translated these ideals into a novel, vibrant, and critical narrative. All of this led many Latin Americans to feel they possessed an innovative and distinctive voice that captured European and North American attention because of its uniqueness.

The type of discourse that prevailed during these years is summarized in one of Che Guevara's speeches at the beginning of the decade:

prevalecer: <i>predominate</i>	to	“There is no small enemy nor any force to be underestimated, because there are no longer any isolated peoples. As the second declaration of Havana states, no people of Latin America is weak, because it is part of a family of two hundred million brothers and sisters who suffer the same miseries, harbor the same feelings, have the same enemy, all dream of the same destiny, and count on the solidarity of all the honest men and women of the world. This epic that lies before us calls to the starving masses of Indians, of landless peasants, of exploited workers, to the progressive masses, to the honest and brilliant intellectuals who abound in our suffering lands of Latin America.” (https://youtu.be/EktbVnKPx6o).
desdeñable: <i>insignificant</i>		
aislado: <i>isolated</i>		
padecer: <i>sufrir</i>		
albergar: <i>to house</i>		
abundar: <i>exist</i> <i>in</i> <i>abundance</i>		

Workers', peasants', and guerrilla movements gained strength in many countries. In fact, there was a spirit of unification among the middle and lower classes around the ideal of building sociopolitical models—like the triumphant Cuban revolution or Salvador Allende's democratic socialism in Chile—that would benefit the majority of the population and not just the elite.

Liberation theology, developed by Christian philosophers from Central and South America such as the Peruvian Gustavo Gutiérrez and the Brazilian Leonardo Boff, proposed applying Gospel principles to the active pursuit of social justice. Liberation pedagogy, proposed by the Brazilian Paulo Freire, created an educational practice designed to promote political action and value the knowledge of people who have suffered socioeconomic oppression for generations. Thinkers like Leopoldo Zea (Mexico) and Enrique Dussel (Argentina) developed a rigorous and alternative philosophy for understanding Latin America in its specificity and dignity. Economists and sociologists such as Enrique Cardoso (Brazil) and Alonso Quijano (Peru) produced a systematic critique of development understood as the imitation of European or American modernization, elaborating an alternative thesis called Dependency Theory, which emphasized the structural change in economic relations at both the global and national levels. For their part, the most famous writers, composers, filmmakers and artists of the time represented in their works the history of marginalization and repression of the people as well as their creative force and aspirations towards more egalitarian and participatory societies.

The "Boom" of narrative

apenas: <i>barely</i> lanzar: <i>to launch</i> hasta entonces: <i>until then</i> convertirse en: <i>to become</i> cúspide: <i>peak</i> rayuela: <i>hopscotch</i> acaparar: <i>to capture, to monopolize</i> habían logrado: <i>had accomplished</i> inaudito: <i>unheard of, extraordinary</i> primermundista: <i>form the first world</i> trama: <i>plot</i> telenovela: <i>soap opera</i>	Latin America then captured the world's attention from 1961 onward, when the communist-leaning government, protected by the Soviet Union, stabilized in Cuba, challenging Washington's hegemony in the hemisphere. The region had become a battleground in the Cold War. In both Europe and the United States, Latin American studies programs proliferated, focused on producing knowledge about that part of the continent which, just a few years earlier, had been barely studied. The Kennedy administration launched the Alliance for Progress, an investment initiative for the (capitalist) development or modernization of Latin America, and began appointing Puerto Ricans as ambassadors to various Spanish-speaking countries to strengthen its ties with the region. The year 1967 was pivotal for Latin American literature, which until then had been largely ignored on the world stage. That year, Guatemalan Miguel Ángel Asturias (1899-1974) became the first Latin American novelist to receive the Nobel Prize in Literature (Chilean Gabriela Mistral had received it for her poetry in 1945). Also in June of that year, the novel <i>One Hundred Years of Solitude</i> by Colombian Gabriel García Márquez (1927-2014) was published, becoming a worldwide bestseller within a few months. It was the pinnacle of the Latin American literary boom, which had begun a few years earlier with the immense popularity of <i>Hopscotch</i> (1963) by Argentine Julio Cortázar (1914-1984), and which also included the work of Peruvian Mario Vargas Llosa (1936-) and Mexican Carlos Fuentes (1928-2012), among others. For the first time in history, Latin American literary production had a leading role on the international stage and, by the year 2000, four other writers had received the Nobel Prize for Literature: Pablo Neruda (Chile) in 1971, García Márquez in 1982, Octavio Paz (Mexico) in 1990 and Derek Walcott (St. Lucia) in 1992. The writers who formed the Latin American Boom, almost all of them left-leaning, captured global attention with a literature that brilliantly combined modern experimentation with distinctive elements of Latin American life and culture. The jungle, myth, oral tradition, the indigenous and African presence, turbulent politics, paradoxical history, and the insatiable search for identity were all integrated into monumental novels whose poetic language captured many of the contradictory experiences of Latin America that were exotic or innovative to the First World. It was, in a way, a replica of what Mexican painters like Diego Rivera, Frida Kahlo, and José Clemente Orozco had achieved in the 1920s and 30s. What was "normal" for Europeans and North Americans appeared as something "magical" to the narrative gaze, and what was unheard of or magical to the First World gaze was described as ordinary everyday life: "García Márquez conjured up a world in his native Colombia where magic was as real as money and ice as magical as dragon's eggs" (Winn 400). This generation had also assimilated the influence of international literature as well as modern mass culture, with novels that included Hollywood plots, tango stories, and soap operas. The new novel sought to represent the heterogeneous and diverse experience of its peoples and to propose alternative models of reality. In this effort, a common ideal emerged, which reinforced the idea of "Latin American" unity.
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Years earlier, in the prologue to the novel *The Kingdom of This World* (1949)—which narrated the Haitian Revolution—the Cuban musicologist and novelist Alejo Carpentier (1904-1980) had proposed the term "marvelous realism" to designate this new fiction that recreated American historical reality in its fertile combination of mythologies and cultural models, from indigenous and African to European and mestizo. Carpentier said:

por: <i>because of</i> paisaje: <i>landscape</i> faústico: <i>like Goethe's Faust, tragic, debased</i> agotar: <i>to exhaust</i>	"Because of the virginity of the landscape, because of the formation, because of the ontology, because of the Faustian presence of the Indian and the black, because of the Revelation that constituted its recent discovery, because of the fertile mestizaje that it fostered, America is far from having exhausted its wealth of mythologies. What is the history of all America but a chronicle of the marvelous real?" (12).
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The Guatemalan writer Miguel Ángel Asturias (1899-1974) had published his novel **Men of Maize** (1949) that same year, which shared this effort to find a language appropriate to the "magical" or surreal experience and to express the need for social transformation. This novel combined surrealist techniques with traditional legends to create a magical reality capable of representing the history of Mayan resistance against the advance of Western culture, interpreting it in their own terms. Meanwhile, Juan Rulfo (1918-1986) and Elena Garro (1916-1998) had explored the bittersweet legacy of the Mexican Revolution, which had not lifted the majority of the population out of poverty, in a narrative that questioned the divisions between the fantastical and the historical. Similar to Octavio Paz, the Argentinian Jorge Luis Borges (1899-1986) differed in his political views from left-wing writers, seeking universal themes in his fiction and poems. His work, however, had an undeniable influence on the Latin American Boom generation, both in its questioning of a unified reality and in its experimentation with labyrinthine narratives that combined cultural heritages as diverse as the Latin American population itself.

By the beginning of the 1960s, a large reading public already existed in Latin America. The expansion of cities and educational opportunities ensured that a growing middle class of professionals and university students avidly read the novels of their favorite authors, with whom they shared ideals of radical transformation of social structures. This enthusiasm was reinforced by the apparent success of the Cuban Revolution, which helped spread a "Latin Americanist" spirit across the continent, transcending national borders and creating a consciousness of political change among the masses. Several Spanish and French publishing houses also launched a major promotional campaign that favored leftist writers and fostered plurinational forums. Thus, three factors combined in the 1960s: first, painting, poetry, and the novel had cultivated a Latin Americanist consciousness and an eager reading public; second, the political left gained considerable strength in many countries of the continent; Third, European publishers encouraged the publication of Latin American works due to public interest in following the processes of change in Latin America during the Cold War.

It was this combination of factors that allowed brilliant novelists like Carlos Fuentes, Mario Vargas Llosa, Gabriel García Márquez, Ernesto Sábato (Argentina 1911-2011), Juan Carlos Onetti (Uruguay 1909-1994), and José Donoso (Chile 1924-1996) to disseminate their works to hundreds of thousands of readers in Latin America, Europe, Asia, and the United States, becoming global stars. Like Borges, they criticized the "provincial" novels of social realism and embraced literary experimentation in dialogue with the most daring trends of the First World.

Unlike Borges, a central theme of the Latin American Boom was Latin American history, a critique of the continent's sociopolitical conditions, and the promotion of a regional identity. *One Hundred Years of Solitude* can be read as an allegory of Colombian history in the story of the Buendía family, and Macondo has been interpreted as a metaphor for Latin America.

By the mid-1970s, military repression had become more brutal throughout the region, Fidel Castro's government was less popular, and revolutionary fervor had waned. The writers of the Latin American Boom then delved deeper into historical themes and the figure of the dictator. Carlos Fuentes, in *Terra Nostra* (1975), criticized the use of history to legitimize present-day injustice. The Paraguayan Augusto Roa Bastos (1917-2005) ridiculed historical documentation and explored the figure of the caudillo José Gaspar de Francia—who had ruled his country for forty years in the 19th century—as a metaphor for the Stroessner dictatorship in his copious novel *I, the Supreme* (1974). Gabriel García Márquez also parodied the endless rhetoric of caudillismo in *The Autumn of the Patriarch* (1975). From the 1980s onward, the era of literary experimentalism and grand collective metaphors came to an end, and all these writers adopted a more realistic and accessible style, in keeping with the commercial demands of the global age. An example of this ideological and aesthetic diversity is the career of Vargas Llosa, who was awarded the Nobel Prize in 2010. His narrative included social commentary in the 1960s and 70s, and later incorporated humor, historical research, and neoliberal ideas.

The legacy of the Latin American Boom continues to be present in various manifestations today associated with the ambiguous "magical realism," a term that has been used to describe the combination of orality and writing in other parts of the world, such as in the novels of Toni Morrison in the United States. During the 1980s and 1990s, a significant number of women writers also enjoyed international recognition. Luisa Valenzuela in Argentina, Isabel Allende and Marcela Serrano in Chile, Laura Restrepo in Colombia, Laura Esquivel in Mexico, Gioconda Belli in Nicaragua, and Nélida Piñón in Brazil are some of the narrators who maintain international attention on Latin American literature and have taken over a literary scene that was traditionally dominated by male figures.

According to many contemporary Latin American writers, it no longer makes sense to associate the continent with a specific style, as it comprises diverse, complex, and pluralistic cultures, in which the so-called "magical realism"—fascinated with the exotic—is just one possibility among many for literary expression of the heterogeneous experience of each region and each individual.

Moreover, most of these cultures are now primarily urban and intimately connected to the processes of commercialization and openness of the 21st century.

Nevertheless, Dependency Theory, the Philosophy, Theology, and Pedagogy of Liberation, and the aesthetics of “magical realism” or the Latin American Boom were important instances where intellectual production from Latin America influenced First World thought during the 1960s and 70s, promoting processes of cultural and political decolonization. All three were cases where a substantial group of Latin Americans saw themselves, understood themselves, and defined themselves as subjects (agents) of knowledge, instead of the traditional position of the colonized, who are seen, understood, and named by others as objects (patients) of knowledge. While this Latin Americanism did not produce the radical socioeconomic changes that many hoped for, it marked a fundamental milestone in the trajectory of collective self-definition in the region. Even today, hip hop groups like *Calle 13* (Puerto Rico) celebrate “Latin American identity” by revisiting the themes of the “Nueva Canción” movement of the 1960s (<http://youtu.be/rqlmJdsfCJc>). Many continue working toward that Latin American unification and justice that the Chilean poet Violeta Parra summarized in 1964:

My life, the American people,
my life, feel distressed,
my life, because the governors,
my life, have them so separated.

When will that moment come, Mr. Prosecutor,
when America will be just one pillar?
Just one pillar, oh yes, and one flag,
when the border disputes will finally end.

I don't want war over a handful of land.

Sources

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For review and reflection

1. What values and circumstances created the Latin Americanist enthusiasm of the 1960s?
2. How could the concept of “Latin Americanism” be defined or explained? What ideological movements does it encompass in theology, philosophy, pedagogy, sociology, etc.? What values and drawbacks does it have as a political ideal?
3. What were some of the reasons why Latin American novels were so successful in Europe and the United States during the 1960s? In what sense(s) is this phenomenon paradoxical?
4. How could the concept of “Magical Realism” be defined or explained? What values and problems does it have as an aesthetic characterization of Latin America?

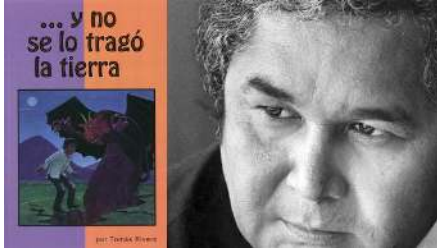
5. What were some of the writers and musical movements that became famous during the novel "Boom" of the 1960s? How has this landscape changed in subsequent decades?

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6.5: Tomás Rivera

Tomás Rivera (1935-1984)

Tomás Rivera was a child of migrant farm workers who overcame tremendous challenges to pursue his education. He wrote about the harsh conditions faced by Mexican farm laborers in his novel *Y no se lo tragó la tierra*. Read the article about the life of Tomás Rivera by [Humanities Texas \[Website\]](#). And read an excerpt from "y no se lo tragó la tierra" below.



 Q8eVF8HfErsk4zP68

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6.6: Sandra Cisneros

 Sandra Cisneros (1954 -)



Sandra Cisneros
Credit: Ray Sartorius

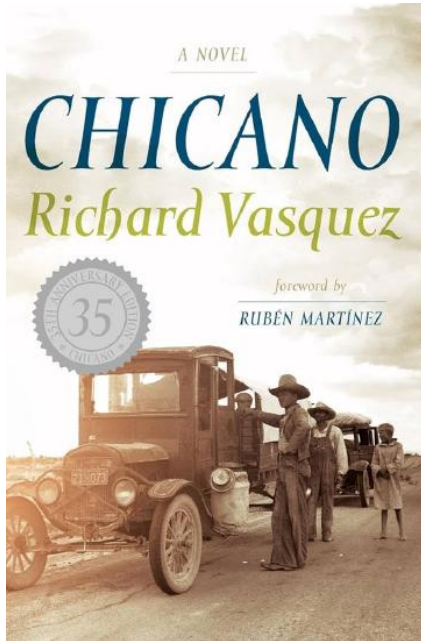
Read about [the life and work of Sandra Cisneros in her own words \[Website\]](#).

Read an excerpt from The House on Mango Street in the file attached below.

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6.7: Richard Vásquez

Richard Vasquez (1928-1990)

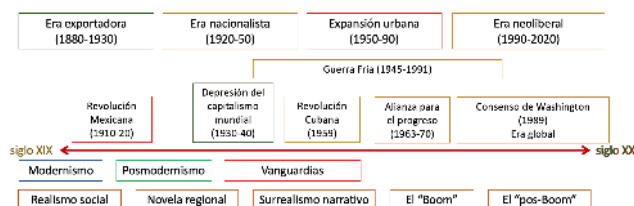


Read his article Mapping Out the Border Lands in the file attached below.

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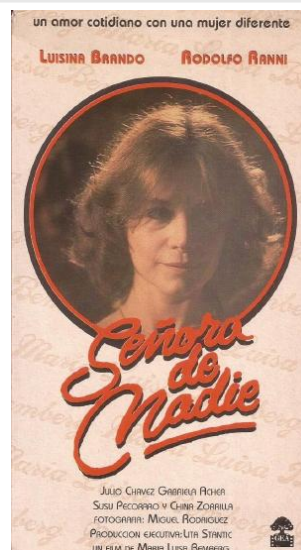
6.8: Hispanoamérica 1970-2010

Referentes históricos para Hispanoamérica durante el siglo XX



The last decades of the 20th century marked a progressive integration of Latin America into the "global era," and at the same time, a growing diversity in the history and cultural production of each country and region. From an era of dictatorships in the 1970s, the region gradually transitioned to a period of democratic governments that favored foreign investment, in what was called the "neoliberal era" or economic liberalization of the 1990s. These predominantly urban societies continue to face the challenge of ensuring that the majority of the population has access to employment, education, healthcare, and consumer goods.

Cinema is one of the fields of cultural production with the widest international reach since the late 20th century, and it serves as a good indicator of sociocultural changes, especially since the 1960s. The film *Señora de nadie* (1982), for example, represents in Leonor, the main character, the growing participation of women in personal and social destinies, as well as the will—and difficulty—of the inhabitants of Latin America to build autonomous societies. At the same time, it symbolizes in Fernando, her husband, the difficulty in trusting governments that, like an unfaithful husband, frequently betray the interests of their own countries for the benefit of foreign investors.



Señora de nadie (1982), dirigida por María Luisa Bemberg (Argentina 1922-1995).

The 1970s

dueño: owner
empresa: business, enterprise
apoyo: support
enfrentado: conflicting

tras: after

allanamiento: raid
amenaza: threat
marcharse: to leave
prensa: press
medidas: measures

prestamista: lending (adj.)
en buena medida: to a large extent
endeudamiento: debts
petróleo: oil (for gas)
préstamo: loan
tasa: rate
evitar: to avoid

As we have seen, the global atmosphere of the Cold War from the 1960s to the 1980s fostered ideological polarization in Latin America and the world. For many leftists, the solution to poverty lay not in reforming capitalist institutions, but in replacing them with a socialist system of production leading to communism, in which all citizens would own the means of production. For many rightists, the only way to preserve institutions and businesses was by suppressing leftist movements through military repression. Both sides received support from their respective opposing world powers (the United States and the Soviet Union).

Following the Latin Americanist movement and revolutionary fervor of the 1960s, Latin American ruling classes favored anti-socialist regimes, often through military dictatorships. By 1976, the military was in control of almost every Latin American country, some populist (Peru), others far-right (Chile). The only exceptions in Latin America during the 1970s were Colombia, Costa Rica, Mexico, the Dominican Republic, and Venezuela, with their limited democratic participation that catered to the expectations of Washington and the elite, controlling—often through heavy military repression—the activism of popular sectors under the “National Security Doctrine.” During those years, thousands of raids, threats, torture, disappearances, and massacres against dissidents were reported, many of whom went into exile (Argentine Adolfo Pérez Esquivel received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1980 for his activism against these abuses). On the other end of the spectrum, Cuba lost credibility as a “free territory of the Americas” because it was unable to eliminate its economic dependence on the Soviet Union. The Castro government also adopted a harder line against internal dissent, increasing the number of political prisoners and becoming increasingly dictatorial. Press censorship and anti-democratic measures thus became widespread in the region. In the most aggressive and best-funded dictatorships, such as those in Chile and Argentina, the political left was virtually dismantled. In Guatemala, El Salvador, and Nicaragua, which did not experience the industrial or urban development of other regions, the rural left-wing guerrilla movement continued to gain strength in the face of the deplorable conditions faced by the peasantry. In the economic sphere, the governments of the 1970s sought to control inflation—with the consequent and unpopular effective reduction of wages—and to favor the expansion of multinational corporations (IBM, Philips, Volkswagen, Bayer, ITT). In response to the lending willingness of North American and European entities such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB), economic growth during these years depended largely on external debt. International banks relied on the massive deposits made by Middle Eastern magnates due to high oil prices and sought reliable clients in need of capital to provide loans at lucrative interest rates. Furthermore, within the context of the Cold War, it was important to finance the social control efforts of Latin American governments to prevent them from falling into the Soviet sphere of influence. Thus, Latin America increased its external debt during the 1970s from \$27 billion to \$231 billion.

The 1980s

tamaño: <i>size</i> sede: <i>headquarters</i>	In the early 1980s, international banks raised interest rates to limit lending to Latin America, as the region's agricultural and mining exports had fallen in price. The largest debtors (Argentina, Brazil, and Mexico) declared themselves unable to pay, and the region's overall economy experienced a cumulative decline of 10%. Lenders, especially the IMF, prescribed strict economic reforms: dismantling domestic protectionism, reducing the size of the state (privatizing public services, for example), promoting new exports, and, above all, facilitating free markets and foreign investment. These reforms are known as neoliberalism or the "Washington Consensus" (named after the headquarters of the international financial institutions that advocated these policies). The political and economic strategies of the previous decade worsened the living conditions of large segments of the population. This created fertile ground for desperate activities such as organized crime and terrorism. Drug trafficking, for example, a transnational, multi-billion-dollar business (nearly \$110 billion annually in the 1990s) that began offering alternative paths to prosperity in the late 1970s, has had a tremendous corrosive impact on societies like those of Colombia and Mexico, to name just two. Partly financed by this trade, illegal armed groups of the extreme left or right emerged or gained new strength in Colombia (FARC, paramilitaries) and Peru (Shining Path, MRTA).
empeorar: <i>to worsen</i> caldo de cultivo: <i>breeding ground</i> narcotráfico: <i>drug trafficking</i>	The event that popular activism greeted with the most enthusiasm in the 1980s was the Nicaraguan Revolution. The Sandinista guerrillas (MSLN) achieved victory over the dictator Anastasio Somoza in 1979, and the new government initiated a series of socialist-style projects (agrarian reform, medical and literacy campaigns) with economic and technical support from the United States, Cuba, Germany, France, and Spain. But the Cold War still played a role, and in 1981 the Ronald Reagan administration began a campaign against "the Marxist-Sandinista takeover of Nicaragua" (trade embargo, military and financial support for the counterrevolutionaries). For the next eight years, the Sandinista government had to invest more resources in defending itself than in improving the conditions of the impoverished majority. The economy was in crisis (inflation in 1988 reached 33,000 percent), and the Sandinistas lost the 1990 elections. Initially encouraged by the Nicaraguan victory, revolutionaries in El Salvador and Guatemala had intensified their struggle during the 1980s (although Washington, for its part, was now providing more support to right-wing governments). However, the Sandinista defeat in the elections made it clear that a left-wing victory in Central America was impossible. By the mid-1990s, the Salvadoran and Guatemalan guerrillas had demobilized and signed peace agreements with their respective governments, an effort that had begun in the 1980s and for which Costa Rican President Óscar Arias received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1987.
alfabetización: <i>literacy</i> analfabetismo: <i>illiteracy</i>	
invertir: <i>to invest</i> empobrecido: <i>impoverished</i>	
por su parte: <i>in turn</i> derrota: <i>defeat</i> acuerdo: <i>agreement</i>	

Almost 80% of the Hispanic American population lives in cities, several of which are among the most populated in the world.

 Buenos Aires, argentina user:Skimg, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons	 Ciudad de México Alejandro Islas Photograph AC, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons	 Santiago, Chile Deensel, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons
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The 1990s and 2000s

a medida que: <i>as</i>	As global communism lost credibility and the Soviet Union dissolved, dictatorships were left without their main justification ("National Security") and without Washington's support. Furthermore, one of the neoliberal premises (and a condition of the IMF) was to attract foreign investment, which tends to favor constitutional stability. Civil protests by middle-class sectors in favor of human rights also exerted internal and external pressure toward democracy. Thus, almost all Latin American countries, except socialist Cuba, had presidents elected by direct vote in 1991, including governments as accustomed to dictatorship as Haiti and Paraguay. In the following years, almost all of these democracies strengthened and expanded, with ups and downs depending on the circumstances of each country. Three general categories can be identified. (1) On the one hand, there are the most open governments, with generally fair and free elections and acceptable respect for the rights of expression and civil organization, as in Costa Rica, Uruguay, and Chile. (2) At the other extreme, there are very restricted and unstable democracies, as in Suriname and Guatemala. (3) Between these two poles, most countries have partial democracies with more or less limited civil rights. Notable examples of presidents elected by popular vote who later acted as dictators are the regimes of Fujimori in Peru in the 1990s and Hugo Chávez in Venezuela in the 2000s. However, the trend in many democratically elected governments has been toward freer and fairer elections in which well-prepared civilian candidates, many from the middle class, participate. Political reforms have been made towards more participatory democracies, such as in the constituent assemblies of Colombia and Ecuador in the nineties, or in the electoral opening of Mexico, which for the first time "dethroned" the PRI in 2000, after seventy years of political monopoly.
habitado: <i>familiar, accustomed</i>	
fortalecer: <i>to strengthen</i>	
ampliar: <i>to widen</i>	
altibajos: <i>ups and downs</i>	
tras: <i>after</i>	

partidos: <i>political parties</i>	Another factor in this democratic expansion has been the resurgence of social activism, which has changed the power dynamics of political parties. Women's organizations, Afro-descendant groups, LGBTQ+ groups, human rights defenders, and many others have highlighted the region's sociocultural heterogeneity, challenging the notion that there is only one answer to popular needs (revolution, socialism). The most notable is the Indigenous movement, which, now separated from the political framework of the Marxist left and with the support of international organizations, has become a pressure group that the state cannot ignore in countries like Ecuador and Bolivia. Key moments for this force were the fall of President Jamil Mahuad in Quito in 1999 and the rise of President Evo Morales in La Paz in 2006. A comparable phenomenon, albeit with different strategies, is the Zapatista Movement in Chiapas, Mexico, which has had a significant influence on the power dynamics in that country since 1994. The Nobel organization recognized the global impact of Indigenous activism by awarding the Nobel Peace Prize in 1992 to Rigoberta Menchú-Tum, a Maya-Quiché activist from Guatemala. This increased national and international visibility of Indigenous and Afro-descendant peoples has led many intellectuals and activists to question the use of the adjective "Latino" to describe this part of the Americas.	
poner de relieve: <i>to highlight</i>	A barometer of the dynamism of popular movements has been the electoral strength of left-wing coalitions in almost every country, which have won the presidency in many of them—something Washington would not have allowed in previous decades. This trend of the first decade of the 21st century has been known as the “Pink Tide , ” because it represents a more moderate ideology than the “red” communism of the 20th century. The political tone differs in each case, but between 2000 and 2009 two lines can be identified: one similar to 20th-century populism with nationalist initiatives, authoritarian tactics, and acts of accelerated constitutional transformation (Venezuela, Ecuador, Bolivia, Nicaragua), and another more centrist with policies that seek to maintain economic growth, favor private investment, and gradually improve wealth distribution (Brazil, Chile, Argentina, Uruguay, Jamaica, Haiti). Both trends favor trade integration between regions with comparable economies (Caricom, Mercosur), but are wary of free trade agreements between overly unequal economies (NAFTA, CAFTA).	
destacable: <i>remarkable, of note</i>	This shift to the left is related to the mixed results of the neoliberal reforms imposed by international banks. On the one hand, inflation was brought under control, and trade liberalization, which included strengthening free trade agreements and increasing foreign investment (Spain alone invested over one hundred billion dollars), produced respectable rates of economic growth: 3.5% on average for Latin America in the 1990s. On the other hand, unemployment did not decrease, social investment declined to cut government spending (less public access to health, education, and housing services, for example), the overall number of homeless people increased, and the gap between rich and poor widened. Latin America has continued to be the region with the worst wealth distribution in the world: in the 1990s, the richest 10% of households received 40% of the income. It is therefore understandable that many voters supported platforms that promised greater social equity. The Uruguayan writer Eduardo Galeano summarized this sentiment as follows:	
viraje: <i>turn, swerve</i>		
equidad: <i>equity, fairness</i>	Para nosotros, el capitalismo no es un sueño a realizar, sino una pesadilla realizada. Nuestro desafío no consiste en privatizar al Estado, sino en desprivatizarlo. [...] Y el mercado no es, para nosotros, más que una nave de piratas: cuanto más libre, peor. [...] Vivimos en una región de precios europeos y salarios africanos, donde [...] el capitalismo es antidemocrático, con o sin elecciones: la mayoría de la gente está presa de la necesidad y está condenada a la violencia” (<i>Apuntes para el fin del milenio</i> . Ecuador: El Conejo, 1979. 71).	<i>Capitalism, to us, is not a dream to make true, but a nightmare made true. Our challenge is not how to privatize the State, but how to make it nonprivate. [...] And the market, to us, is but a ship of pirates -the freer, the worse. [...] We live in a region of European prices and African salaries, in which capitalism is antidemocratic, whether with elections or not. Most people are prey to necessity and condemned to violence.</i>

desempleo: <i>unemployment</i>	Unemployment and rising poverty have also contributed to the increase in drug trafficking and emigration. Paradoxically, one of the cornerstones of Washington's post-Cold War policy toward the Americas has been responding to these two phenomena, which were unintentionally exacerbated by the very measures recommended by the "Washington Consensus." The "war on drugs" of the 1980s and 1990s gave the Pentagon a justification for maintaining some of its military investment in Latin America (which had been substantial during the Cold War). The 1989 invasion of Panama was justified in these terms. In the 2000s, however, the "war on terror" provided the military justification, so the trafficking of illegal substances ceased to be treated as a matter of war. But its increase along the Mexican border led to a renewed analysis of the issue from the perspective of U.S. security. Adding another dimension to the concept of "globalization," the large number of Latin Americans who have emigrated—with or without visas—to the United States since the 1970s, and to Europe and Asia since the 1990s, is also changing the very concept of Latin America. The 2000 census revealed the surprising fact that the United States had almost 40 million Spanish speakers, surpassed only by Mexico, Colombia, and (possibly) Argentina. [1] To give just one economic example of their impact, the Inter-American Development Bank
eje: <i>axis</i>	
medidas: <i>measures</i> el propio: <i>itself</i> añadir: <i>to add</i>	

cifra: *figure*
ingreso: *income*

estimated that in 2006 these emigrants sent approximately US\$62.3 billion from the United States to their home countries, a figure higher than the region's foreign investment that year (López-Córdova & Olmedo, p. 1). For some nations, this income is almost as significant as export revenue. Politically and culturally, this presence, which in the U.S. is associated with the term "Latinos," is equally transformative, as it alters the American electoral game and fosters a continental consciousness, no longer from treaties between governments, but from daily coexistence, which is not always harmonious.

[1] Some of these 40 million did not immigrate, but are descended from those who lived in the Mexican territories that the United States annexed in the mid-19th century (Texas, California, New Mexico, etc.).

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6.9: Mexican-American Poetry- Los Chicanos

El término “chicano/a”



Chicano Park en San Diego. [kellinahandbasket](#)

En su libro *Chicano Folklore*, Rafaela Castro explica que un **chicano** es una persona de ascendencia mexicana nacida en los EE.UU. Muchos mexicano-americanos nacidos en los Estados Unidos se consideran chicanos para enfatizar e identificar su **herencia** mexicana e indígena. Castro señala que hay varios mitos del **origen** de la palabra. Algunos dicen que el término viene del estado mexicano *Chihuahua* y la palabra *mexicano* (*Chihuahua / Mexicano* → *Chicano*) (46). Otras personas piensan que la palabra “chicano” es de **origen** náhuatl, el idioma principal de los aztecas. Ellos le llamaban a su territorio Mexica (pronunciado [me'shi.ka]), una palabra que suena muy similar a “chicano”.

En los 1960s los jóvenes y los estudiantes universitarios empezaron a utilizar “chicano/a” en sus movimientos políticos para demostrar su **identidad** cultural. Como señala Castro, Chicano/a “has become an ideologically loaded symbolic code word that expresses cultural pride in a common Mexican heritage. To call oneself Chicano symbolizes a solidarity with the Spanish language and with a pre-Columbian indigenous past, and an understanding of American racial oppression and discrimination against Mexican-Americans” (46). Por esto, el término tiene tanto que ver con ser mexicano-americano como con la posición política de una persona.

El movimiento chicano

El Movimiento Chicano comenzó en los años 1960s con el deseo de mejorar el tratamiento de mexicano-americanos en varios sectores: la política, la educación, y el trabajo — especialmente en los campos agrícolas. Este movimiento se inspiró en parte por el movimiento de derechos civiles dirigido por Martin Luther King Jr. y ganó mucho apoyo entre los estudiantes universitarios, quienes empezaron a interesarse en su **identidad** y a valorar su herencia indígena mexicana. Uno de estos grupos se llama [MEChA](#), [Movimiento Estudiantil Chicano de Aztlán](#). Aztlán es el nombre del antiguo territorio de los aztecas.

Un líder importante en el movimiento de los trabajadores agrícolas fue César Chávez, quien luchó durante toda su vida por los derechos de mexicano-americanos. Chávez nació en Yuma, Arizona de padres que vivían como campesinos migratorios. En 1962, él creó el sindicato “[United Farm Workers](#)” (UFW) para mejorar los derechos y las condiciones de los trabajadores. En 1965 organizó una huelga para obtener mejores contratos para los trabajadores. El Movimiento Chicano promociona la **identidad** de los mexicano-americanos e intenta corregir los estereotipos negativos de los mexicanos en los Estados Unidos sin emplear la violencia. Aunque Chávez falleció en 1993, UFW sigue trabajando para mejorar las condiciones en los campos.

Expresiones artísticas chicanas



Chicano Batman [Raph_PH](#)

Desde 1960, las expresiones artísticas chicanas han sido herramientas de activismo político y han ayudado a crear un sentido de comunidad entre los mexicano-americanos. Los enlaces a continuación incluyen ejemplos de los artistas que jugaron un papel importante cuando el movimiento comenzó en 1960 pero también de artistas más recientes que rompen con los moldes tradicionales.

El arte chicano

La meta de la [nueva generación](#) de chicanos es criticar y denunciar los estereotipos negativos sobre los mexicano-americanos y defender los derechos de los inmigrantes.

- [Art as Resistance: Chicano Artists in the Time of Trump](#)
- [‘Bridges in a Time of Walls’ Brings Chicano Art to Mexico City](#)
- [8 Influential Chicano and Chicano Artists in LA](#)
- [Chicano Mural Movement](#)

La música chicana

- [Chicano Batman: ‘Four Latinos Breaking into Rock Music and Succeeding’](#)
- [The New Generation of Chicano Soul Wave](#)
- [Songs of the Chicano Movement](#)
- [Documental: Chicano Rock! The Sounds of East Los Angeles](#)

La literatura chicana

Tradicionalmente, la literatura chicana explora temas como la identidad, el biculturalismo, el bilingüismo, y la vida en la frontera. Autores chicanos incluyen a Rudolfo Anaya, Sandra Cisneros, y Lorna Dee Cervantes. En 2003, Alisa Valdes-Rodriguez publicó una novela de “Chica lit” que se llama *The Dirty Girls Social Club*. Esta novela representa una ruptura con la literatura chicana tradicional. Como dice Valdes-Rodriguez en el [artículo](#), “‘I’m an Ivy League graduate, middle-class person who just lives a regular American life — you know, born and raised here, don’t speak all that much Spanish — and there are lots and lots of people like me.’”

- [Fall and Rise of Dirty Girls’ Author](#)
- [A Chicano Poem by Lorna Dee Cervantes](#)
- [13 Chicano-Lit Must Reads](#)
- [Chicano Literature: The Theme of Cultural Resistance](#)

El cine chicano

- [What Does It Mean To Be Chicano?](#)
- [History of Chicano Cinema’s Rise](#)
- [Stereotypes in the Media](#)
- [What Coco Means to Mexican-Americans](#)

(Fuentes: Castro, Rafaela. *Chicano Folklore*. Oxford UP, 2000).

Almanaque creado por [Karen Acosta](#) y modificado por Mirla González.

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6.10: Cómo leer la poesía

(Translated from Spanish)

Why express oneself through poetry?

Poetry is a genre that can respond to any human circumstance to express how we feel or experience the world. By communicating through poetry, the poet engages with a long tradition, with both formal and informal patterns and practices. There are three broad categories of poetry: dramatic (plays in verse), epic (narrative, often with heroic themes), and lyric (more subjective, contemplative—this style is what usually comes to mind when one thinks of poetry). Some poets seek the challenge of writing within certain inherited forms, such as the sonnet, the epigram, the elegy, or an ode. Others employ poetic devices within free verse. Poetic expression has its roots in orality and maintains these ties through time through the ballads and romances of the Middle Ages; the gaucho payadas of the 19th and 20th centuries in the Southern Cone; improvised and sung poetry throughout the centuries; and the more recent spoken word poetry or rap. In poetry there is generally more emphasis on connotation, or the figurative implications of words, the meaning beyond the literal or explicit sense.

The examples of poetry included in this text come from a variety of countries and historical periods and exemplify distinct forms and themes. Some deal explicitly with health, while others show the range of experiences that can be addressed through poetry. In the field of medicine, poetry sometimes appears as an activity or therapy that “can enhance resilience and reduce anxiety in people with cancer,” [1] a way of negotiating one’s place and purpose in society, or an activity of self-representation and creativity that can contribute to “grassroots expressions of public health.” [2] It can even be useful for those working in the medical field itself to express the successes and difficulties of working with the boundaries between illness and health, as illustrated by the poems and essays of Rafael Campo, a Cuban-American poet and physician. [3]

Examples of poetic expression appear in almost every section of this book; Chapter 5, “Body, Gender, and Sexuality,” in particular, allows us to explore poetic expressions in depth. You may refer to the ideas and terms explained here as you explore how poetry expresses a multitude of human situations and feelings.

Basic terms for talking about poetry

- **Poetry** is a cultural form; a **poem** is a poetic text. The word is masculine, despite ending in “a”, thanks to its Greek origin.
- **The poet** and **the poetess** are the terms used to refer to the person who writes the poem. They can also refer to the poetic voice.
- **The poetic speaker (poetic I, lyric speaker, poetic voice, poet):** These words are used to refer to the “person” who speaks within the poem; he or she has a role parallel to the narrator in fiction.
- To talk about the **content of the poem**, terms such as **theme**, **message**, **story**, and **ideas** can be used.

Poetry is evocative: it communicates through connotation

Language can be **denotative** or **connotative**. **Denotative** language refers objectively to something; for example, a star is literally a celestial body. **Connotative** language carries, in addition to its literal meaning, another expressive sense; the connotations of “star” include someone who excels in their field or destiny. The resources mentioned here infuse language with connotations and can communicate directly to the emotions of readers and listeners. They communicate an effect or idea more intensely, often by drawing a comparison between the poem’s new idea and an experience the readers have shared.

An **image** is something perceived through one of the five senses—sight, hearing, taste, touch, or smell. It is also the representation in words or in the mind of a sensation. Images lend sensuality to a text. The more detailed and precise the description of an image, the more sensuality it adds to the text. Sometimes its literary value lies in the sensuality itself and the pleasure it evokes.

Figurative language: analogy, tropes, and other figures

- **Analogy** refers to the similarity between different things. Poetry uses various forms of analogy, including **metaphor**, **simile**, **symbol**, **archetype**, **synecdoche**, and **metonymy**. These uses of language are also called **figurative language**, language whose meaning differs from the literal meaning.
- Perhaps the most central trope in poetry is **the metaphor**. Images often carry a **metaphorical** meaning. With a metaphor, the poet unites two objects and suggests a new relationship between them through a perceived resemblance. In José Martí’s “Verse

V" (below), the poet employs a metaphor when he refers to his verse as "a mountain of foam," attributing to it the qualities of lightness, abundance, and transience.

- A **simile** also makes a comparison, but unlike a metaphor, the comparison is made explicit with the word "like" or "as." Martí also uses a simile in "Verse V" when he says, "My verse is like a dagger."
- A **symbol** compares two elements, often based on an image, but it does so with reference to the cultural world in which the poet lives. The symbol generally has a "universal" meaning, that is, a widely recognized meaning. In dominant European and American cultures, for example, the rose has come to be understood as a symbol of beauty and the color white as a symbol of purity.
- An **archetype** is a fundamental model, a paradigm of a concept: the hero, the orphan, the widow, the fairy godmother, the witch, God, Heaven, Hell. It is a concept that we may carry in our subconscious and that affects how we understand the world and how we react to cultural texts.
- Synecdoche also involves a culturally determined comparison, in which a part or example represents the whole object or group. In the expression "daily bread," bread—a staple food—represents everything necessary for life. When it is said that "Spain won the match," the name of the nation—Spain—represents a sports team made up of Spanish players.
- In **metonymy**, which is also culturally determined, there is a close association between the object or concept being named and the idea, person, or process to which it refers. In the expression "the sword and the pen," for example, it refers to a person's capacity to perform military duties (the sword) and intellectual activities (the pen). In the following sentence, the word "crown" is a metonym referring to the power to govern: "The marriage of Isabella and Ferdinand united the crowns of Castile and Aragon."

Other transformations and turns of language

There are other poetic resources that give language an additional or different meaning than the literal one.

- **The apostrophe** represents a "turn" in language, as it marks a moment when the poetic voice addresses a person, animal, idea, or object directly, whether inside or outside the poem. The poetic voice shifts from speaking in the third person to using the second person—you. The poetic voice can use the apostrophe to intensify the expression of emotions, to address an absent being intimately, or to create personification. Several poems in this collection feature a continuous apostrophe—the entire poem is addressed to a "you"—such as the poems by César Vallejo and Rosario Castellanos in Part II (chapter 5). In others, the apostrophe interrupts and expresses a change in the poetic voice's attitude, as in "The Grandfather" by Nicolás Guillén (chapter 5). Here the poet begins by speaking of a woman in the third person, "This angelic woman with northern eyes," but in the first tercet he addresses her directly, "Ah, my lady!"
- In **antithesis**, two elements or ideas are contrasted—such as cold and heat or honesty and corruption. The expressive force of antithesis is greater if it is presented with parallel syntax, as in Enrique Lihn's poem (Part II (Chapter 3) "There are only two countries": "There are only two countries: the country of the healthy and the country of the sick") and in "To Julia de Burgos," where the poet says: "You are a cold doll of social lies, / and I, a virile flash of human truth"; the parallelism is seen in the structure of adjective (cold/virile) + noun (doll / flash) + of + quality to be contrasted (social lie / human truth).
- **Hyperbole** is exaggeration, as in saying, "I almost died of fright."
- In **irony**, the poet seeks to communicate something different from what is literally said, sometimes even its opposite, as if exclaiming after a car accident, "How fabulously lucky I am!" Irony requires a relationship of mutual understanding between the speaker and the listener; otherwise, the meaning fails.
- In a **paradox**, the two parts of an opposition or antithesis are united in a seemingly impossible way, yet they communicate a complex conceptual truth. Saint Teresa of Ávila conveys the impossibility of describing mystical experience through paradox: "I live without living in myself / and such a high life I await / that I die because I do not die."
- In **personification**, the speaker attributes human qualities to an animal or inanimate object. In "Sonnet XXIII", Garcilaso personifies spring with the adjective "joyful" and time with the adjective "angry" (arrogant).

Poetry is music: it organizes sound

- **Rhyme** is the matching of sounds at the end of lines of verse or, with **internal rhyme**, within a line. Rhyme lends musicality to a poem. It can link two or more words to enrich meaning. It can help a spoken poet remember and create verses spontaneously.

It can also draw attention to the poet's wit.

- **Consonant rhyme** is a rhyme that includes both vowels and consonants.
- **Assonant rhyme** includes only the vowels.
- A **blank verse** does not rhyme with others.

Versification

- A **verse** is a single line of poetry. It does not have the same meaning as the word "verse" in English.
- An **acute verse** has the accent on the last syllable: "I live without living in **myself**" (Saint Teresa of Jesus).
- A **plain verse** has the accent on the penultimate syllable. "And such a high life is **but**" ("I live without living in myself" by Saint Teresa of Jesus).
- A **proparoxytone verse** has the accent on the antepenultimate syllable. "And your slender and agile shadow / fine and **languid**" ("Nocturne III by José Asunción Silva, Part II, Chapter 5).
- **Meter** is the measure or length of a verse. A **verse of minor art** has fewer than 9 syllables. A **verse of major art** has 9 or more syllables.
- A **caesura** is a pause in the voice within a line of verse. A **hemistich** is half a line of verse divided in two by a caesura. A **synalepha** is the merging of the last vowel of one word with the first vowel of the next. **Enjambment** is the way in which the voice continues without pause from one line of verse to the next because the syntax links the meaning of the words.

The "Verse V" of *Versos sencillos* by the poet José Martí is a quatrain, a stanza of four verses.

Each verse has eight syllables:

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	Rhyme
	Yo	soy	un	hom	bre	sin	ce	ro	A
	de	don	de	cre	ce	la	pal	ma.	B
	Y_an	tes	de	mo	rir	me	quie	ro	A
	E	char	los	ver	sos	del	al	ma.	B

The quatrain has an ABAB **consonant rhyme**:

- ero
- alma
- ero
- alma

How to count syllables:

- If there is a consonant between two vowels, the consonant goes with the second vowel: cre / ce, mo / rir.
- They cannot be separated: p, b, f, c, g plus l or r: a/pro/piar, a/flo/jar.
- They also cannot be separated: t, d plus r: cua/tro, cua/dro, pie/dra.
- In other cases of 2 consonants, the two are divided: ár/bol, es/pan/to, car/ne.
- When three or more consonants appear between two vowels, the last two form a group: in/fla/mar, con/tra/er, em/ple/a/dos. But if the first consonants are ns, they stay together: cons/tar, ins/tau/rar.
- The contact between two low vowels (a, e, o) requires 2 distinct syllables: a/é/re/o, pe/le/ar, le/a.
- If a low vowel and a high vowel (i, u) form a diphthong, it constitutes one syllable: ai/re, a/sia, bue/no.
- A triphthong forms a separate syllable: a/so/ciáis, buey.

- A high accented vowel + a low unaccented vowel = two distinct syllables: ha/bí/a, pa/ís.

The stanzas

- A **stanza** is a group of several lines of verse. A poem may have stanzas with a structure defined by the number of lines, their length (meter), and their rhyme scheme. Others have flexible stanzas or no stanzas at all.
- A **quatrain** is a stanza of four verses.
- Un **romance** es un poema de avess octosílabos con rima asonante de los aves pares.
- A **sonnet** is a poem of fourteen lines. The lines are generally hendecasyllabic (11 syllables) or alexandrine (14 syllables) with consonant rhyme. The rhyme scheme varies, but it typically groups the lines into two quatrains and two tercets. Examples include ABAB CDCD EFE FEF and ABBA CDDC EFG EFG.
- **Free verse** is poetry that does not have a clear rhyme or meter pattern.

Figures that contribute to the musicality of poetry

- **Alliteration** is the repetition of consonant sounds to create an auditory effect. In “Cuerpo de mujer” (chapter 5), Blas de Otero uses alliteration with the letter “t” in the first tercet of the sonnet:

*Cuerpo de la mujer, fuente de llanto
donde, después de tanta luz, de tanto
tacto sutil, de Tántalo es la pena.*

*In English: "Woman's body, source of tears
where , after so much light, so much
subtle touch , the pain of Tantalus is found."*

Alliteration can contribute to the meaning and effect of a poem in many different ways. In this case, the alliteration seems to connect the meanings of the words *tanta/tanto*, *tacto*, and *Tantalus*. Tantalus is the name of a son of the god Zeus who suffered the punishment of eternal thirst and hunger: although he had to stand by a lake and was very close to the fruit of a tree, whenever he tried to drink the water or pick the fruit, they moved away from him. The alliteration in Otero's verses connects Tantalus's punishment with touch—the inability to touch the woman—and with the word *tanta/tanto*, which indicates abundance: with such abundance, the poet cannot touch the woman's body.

- **Anaphora** also involves repetition, but of one or more words at the beginning of a phrase, verse, or clause. The repetition of the words “en tanto” in Garcilaso de la Vega’s “Sonnet XXIII” (chapter 4) is an example of anaphora: the two instances of the expression occur at the beginning of two adjacent clauses. The effects of anaphora are diverse: it can add emphasis, draw attention, create acceleration or deceleration, soothe, or intensify emotion. It is a common figure of speech in political rhetoric. Consider, for example, Martin Luther King Jr.’s “I Have a Dream” speech. What effect does it have on Garcilaso’s sonnet?
- **Hyperbaton** changes the usual word order. Hyperbaton is often used to give the poet flexibility to place emphasis where they wish in a verse and to aid with rhyme, by placing a certain word at the end of the line even if it means inverting the word order. The exaggerated use of hyperbaton in the Spanish Baroque period—in the 17th century—was also related to the desire to showcase the poet's wit. The first two lines of Garcilaso's "Sonnet XXIII," in which the poet admires his beloved, are:

*En tanto que de rosa y azucena
se muestra la color en vuestro gesto
y que vuestro mirar ardiente, honesto
Enciende al corazón y lo refrena...*^[4]

*In English: "While the color of rose and lily
is shown in your gesture
and your ardent, honest gaze*

ignites the heart and restrains it..."

The conventional word order would be, "En tanto que la color de rosa y azucena se muestra en vuestro gesto ..." Hyperbaton allows Garcilaso to arrange two hendecasyllabic verses and create a consonant rhyme between "azucena (lily)" and "refrena (restrain)," and "gesto (gesture)" and "honesto (honest)". It allows the emphasis at the end to fall on "refrenar" that is, halting the man's advances toward the woman. It also allows the words "gesto" and "honesto" to be associated through the rhyme and their placement at the end of verses 2 and 3, thus linking honesty with the lady's face.

The application of poetic concepts



José Martí (1853-1895)

José Julián Martí Pérez (1853-1895) is a national hero in Cuba, renowned for his poetry, essays, journalism, and political activism. He was imprisoned at the age of 16 on charges of treason by the Spanish government. He served two years of his sentence and was exiled to Spain at the age of 18. With an anti-imperialist ideology, he fought for Cuban independence throughout his life but never actually returned to live there. Instead, he traveled and lived in Mexico, Guatemala, Venezuela, and the United States. According to Eugenio de Florit, he wrote the poetry collection *Versos sencillos* (*Simple Verses*) at the foot of the Catskill Mountains in New York, seeking simplicity through formal elegance at the beginning of the literary movement known as Spanish American Modernism. [5] Martí returned to his country and died at the Battle of Dos Ríos about four years after the publication of this book.

de José Martí

*Si ves un monte de espumas,
Es mi verso lo que ves:
Mi verso es un monte, y es
Un abanico de plumas.*

*Mi verso es como un puñal
Que por el puño echa flor:
Mi verso es un surtidor
Que da agua de coral.*

*Mi verso es de un verde claro
Y de un carmín encendido:*

*Mi verso es un ciervo herido
Que busca en el monte amparo.*

*Mi verso al valiente agrada:
Mi verso, breve y sincero,
Es del vigor del acero
Con que se funde la espada.*

Versos sencillos (1891)

*If you see a mountain of foam,
it is my verse you see:
My verse is a mountain, and it is
a fan of feathers.*

*My verse is like a dagger
That blossoms from its hilt:
My verse is a fountain
That gives forth coral water.*

*My verse is light green
and bright crimson:
My verse is a wounded deer
that seeks refuge in the mountains.*

*My verse pleases the brave:
My verse, brief and sincere,
Is of the vigor of the steel
With which the sword is forged.*

Simple Verses (1891)

How to read the poem:

1. Begin by reading the entire poem to grasp its overall meaning. Don't forget the importance of the title: *Simple Verses*.
2. Look up the words you don't know.
3. Who is the poetic speaker? Where are they? What do we learn about them in the poem? (Note: if the speaker is going to state that they are a woman or a man, there must be indications of gender in the text.) The poetic voice may be almost entirely absent from the poem; what does this distance imply? In "V" we learn that the speaker is a poet ("my verse") and we learn a great deal about their philosophy of poetry, what they want to do with their verse.
4. What is the tone of the poem? What are the central themes? Here, the theme is poetry, its role in life. The tone is strong and confident: the speaker makes a series of assertions about the nature of their poetry.
5. What are some of the poetic devices used? It helps to make a list of some of these based on the terms already presented. Other devices the author uses are: parallelism; oppositions; repetitions of sounds, words, ideas, and images; symbols (and we learn what they represent according to the context within the poem and the cultural context); and similar and contrasting words. Each stanza begins with "my verse is" (anaphoric repetition); the repetition draws attention to his multiple attempts to define his poetry. In "V," there are a series of comparisons, and therefore, it seems that his poetry is many things or fulfills many roles at once. Many of these comparisons are metaphors ("my verse is...") and relate his verse to a mountain and a fan of feathers in the first stanza.

6. What do these images have in common? Their placement in the poem suggests a relationship between them (a certain parallelism). Are they similar or different? *There is a shift in the series of metaphors, however, in the second stanza, which becomes apparent when one begins to connect one metaphor to another: "My verse is like a dagger." Now we see a simile; perhaps the shift indicates a different relationship between the elements in this instance. Is there anything different about this comparison?*
7. What is the rhythm, rhyme, and versification like here? What does it have to do with the poem's meaning? *Here, the poem deals with poetry itself, and when the speaker describes what their poetry is, they support this within the poem. It's simple, with a strong consonant rhyme scheme (abba) that lends a certain unity to each stanza and a strong, song-like rhythm. That's why it's easy to remember. The rhyme also creates an association between terms: foams/feathers, you see/are (linked by both meaning and sound). Supported by the relatively simple language, the regular rhyme makes the poem seem more straightforward.*
8. What is the poem's trajectory? Are there different parts, changes, pauses, or other units within the poem itself? What is the relationship between the poem and the book in which it appears? (Is it part of a series?) What is the relationship between the poem and what we know about the author? What is its relationship to the historical moment and literary tradition?
9. Does seeking more information about the cultural and historical context in which this poem was produced change how we understand it?

Créditos

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1. Mi traducción, Tegner, et al. *Journal of Poetry Therapy* 22:3; 121-131. [↩](#)
 2. Crawford, et. al. 129 Crawford, Paul, Brian Brown, Carly Baker, Victoria Tischler, Brian Abrams. *Health Humanities*. Palgrave MacMillan, 2015. [↩](#)
 3. In his book *The Healing Art*, Campo distinguishes between the activity of remedying ([mend](#)) versus curing or healing in his own practice and in the poems of others. [↩](#)
 4. While rose and lily color your face, and your ardent and honest gaze ignite the heart and restrain it... [↩](#)
 5. de Florit, Eugenio. "Los versos de Martí." En *José Martí, Versos*, editado por de Florit. Las Américas Publishing Co., 1962: 7-63. [↩](#)

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6.11: Rodolfo "Corky" Gonzales

[Click here to read the poem "I am Joaquín" \[Website\]](#) by Rodolfo "Corky" Gonzales.

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6.12: Alurista

Read the poem *Pa' Césary Corky* by Alurista here [Website].

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6.13: Francisco X. Alarcón

Francisco X. Alarcón (1954-2016) Selected Poems Mexican-American Contemporary Literature Francisco Alarcón was a Chicano poet, who gained success in both the U.S. and Spanish-speaking nations, even though he wrote primarily in Spanish. Alarcón was born in California but lived in Guadalajara, Mexico from the age of 6 until he returned to California at age 18. After working in California restaurants and as a migrant farm worker, Alarcón graduated from California State University, Long Beach with a B.A. in Spanish and History. At Stanford University, he studied contemporary Latin American literature. While studying at Stanford, Alarcón became part of the area literary community and began doing poetry readings. In 1985, he published his first book of poems, *Tattoos*. Studying on a Fulbright scholarship in Mexico City, he discovered Aztec incantations, which became the basis for his third volume of poetry, *Snake Poems: An Aztec Invocation*. In 1985, Alarcón also became one of the founders of *Las Cuarto Espinas*, the first gay Chicano poets collective, which published the collection *Ya Vas Carnal*. Alarcón taught Spanish at UC-Davis and co-authored the textbook *Mundo 21*, still a popular text, published by Cengage. Alarcón published poems in three languages: Spanish, English, and Nahuatl. His style is considered minimalist, though lyrical, with short lines and stanzas. According to the website for the Academy of American Poets, the poems "explore mestizo culture and identity, American identity, sexuality, Mesoamerican history, and mythology." Alarcón won the 1993 American Book Award, Carlos Pellicer-Robert Frost Poetry Honor Award, Chicano Literary Prize, Fred Cody Lifetime Achievement Award, and the 1993 PEN Oakland Josephine Miles Award. At the time of his death, in January 2016, Alarcón was lecturer of Spanish and director of the Spanish for Native Speakers program at UC-Davis. "To Those Who Have Lost Everything" (2002), "Prayer" (2002), and "'Mexican' is not a Noun" (2002) were published in Alarcón's 2002 collection *The Other Side of Night [Del otro lado de la noche]*. All are characteristic of Alarcón's style, written as a series of brief, unpunctuated verses with little capitalization. Each of the three poems also focuses on an aspect of Chicano culture: the experience of crossing the border into the United States, discrimination faced by Mexican-Americans, and efforts to protest unfair treatment. Consider while reading:

1. Identify the speaker in each poem—what is the tone of the poem? What emotion is the speaker expressing?
2. Although these poems are brief, Alarcón uses poetic techniques and figurative language. Identify the crafted elements you notice.
3. What political or social statements does Alarcón make in these three poems?

Written by Anita Turlington

[Read "Mexican" Is Not a Noun here \[Website\].](#)

[Read Prayer here \[Website\].](#)

[Read To Those Who Have Lost Everything here \[Website\].](#)

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6.14: Historical Antecedents

In the next section, you will learn about some of the historical antecedents that form the cultural context and provide inspiration for modern Mexican-American poetry.

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6.15: El corrido mexicano

Step 1

Read this summary of the history of the Mexican corrido, and its subgenre, the narcocorrido.



Los Tigres del Norte at the Apollo Theater
([Alterna2](#))

The corrido is a musical genre in Mexico that tells the true story of a real and/or mythical figure. These epic compositions narrate important moments to pay homage and show respect to a person or a people.

The corrido originated in the early 19th century during the War of Independence and gained immense popularity during the Mexican Revolution (1910-1920) because it recounted the adventures of revolutionaries and their leaders. Corridos remain popular today. They continue to tell the heartfelt stories of community members and their most pressing issues, such as immigration. Instead of focusing on revolutionary leaders, they now tell the stories of unsung heroes who die trying to cross the border into the United States. Another popular theme in contemporary corridos is drug trafficking; these corridos are called “narcocorridos.”

Narcocorridos are heavily influenced by norteño music, incorporating the accordion rhythm and drawing inspiration from the waltz and polka. Traditionally, they were music of rural areas, but recently corridos have become popular in Mexican and American cities. According to Elijah Wald, author of the book *Narcocorrido* (2002), in the 1990s more than two-thirds of the Latin music records sold in the United States were by Mexican narcocorrido artists. Thus, in the U.S., Los Angeles became the epicenter of the genre.

After the death of narcocorrido singer “Chalino” Sánchez in 1992, some people began to criticize the music because it glorified violent and illegal activity. In fact, in 2002, during Vicente Fox’s presidency, corridos were banned on some local radio stations, especially in the north and central parts of the country, as a measure to help eradicate the growing violence in these regions. However, narcocorridos remain popular today and have a devoted following.

Fuente: [BBC News](#)

Step 2

Now listen to the narcocorrido “Contrabando y Traición” by [Los Tigres del Norte](#), one of the most well-known groups in this musical style. As you listen, follow along with the lyrics to better understand the words and the message. We will discuss the song in class.



[Transcripción \(.docx\)](#)

Contrabando y Traición

Salieron de San Isidro procedentes de Tijuana
Traían las llantas del carro repletas de hierba mala
Eran Emilio Barela y Camelia la Tejana

Pasaron por San Clemente, los paró la inmigración
Les pidió sus documentos, les dijo ¿de dónde son?
Ella era de San Antonio, una hembra de corazón

Una hembra si quiere a un hombre por él puede dar la vida
Pero hay que tener cuidado si esa hembra se siente herida
La traición y el contrabando son cosas incompartidas

A Los Ángeles llegaron, a Hollywood se pasaron
En un callejón oscuro las 4 llantas cambiaron
Allí entregaron la hierba y ahí también les pagaron

Emilio dice a Camelia hoy te das por despedida
Con la parte que te toca tú puedes rehacer tu vida
Yo me voy pa' San Francisco con la dueña de mi vida

Sonaron siete balazos Camelia a Emilio mataba
La policía sólo halló una pistola tirada
Del dinero y de Camelia... nunca más se supo nada.

Fuente: arlindo-correia.com

In English: Smuggling and Treason

They left San Ysidro, coming from Tijuana.
They were bringing tires full of weed.
They were Emilio Barela and Camelia la Tejana.

Passing through San Clemente, immigration stopped them.
He asked for their documents, he asked them where they were from.
She was from San Antonio, a woman at heart.

A woman who loves a man can give her life for him.
But one must be careful if that woman feels hurt.
Betrayal and smuggling are things that cannot be shared.

They arrived in Los Angeles, they went to Hollywood.
In a dark alley they changed all four tires.
There they delivered the weed and there they got paid.

Emilio tells Camelia, "Today you're done.
With your share, you can rebuild your life.
I'm going to San Francisco with the love of my life."

Seven shots rang out when Camelia killed Emilio.
The police only found a gun lying on the ground.
Of the money and of Camelia... nothing more was ever heard.

Otras actividades

1. Analyze the lyrics of “Contrabando y Traición”: Where does the action take place? What are the main themes? (violence, love, migration, betrayal, money, etc.); Why do you think narcocorridos are popular? Do you think this music is problematic? Should narcocorridos be censored? Are there similar themes or styles in the U.S.?
2. BBC Mundo invited readers to write a unique corrido, with **lyrics** against **drug trafficking** , and some can be heard here in the article “[Write a Corrido Against Drug Trafficking](#) .” Listen to other corridos, and then write (in groups) the **lyrics** to your own anti-drug corrido (or another type of corrido).

Almanaque creado por Megan Thornton.

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- [4.4.4: ¿Qué es el corrido mexicano?](#) by Amy Rossomondo, editor is licensed [CC BY-NC 4.0](#). Original source: <https://acceso.ku.edu/>.

6.16: Poemas nahuas y quechuas

(Translated from Spanish)

▮ [Más poemas en: Muestra de poesía en náhuatl y en quechua.](#)

When Europeans arrived in the Americas in 1492, there were numerous groups of people with very different ways of life and thought. All of these civilizations had their own songs, poetry, and stories. Two civilizations that greatly impressed Europeans at the time were the Aztec civilization in the Valley of Mexico (whose official language was Nahuatl, also spoken by other neighboring cultures and with almost two million speakers today), and the Inca civilization (whose language is Quechua or Runasimi, spoken today by almost ten million people), in what is now Peru, northern Chile and Argentina, Ecuador, southern Colombia, and parts of Bolivia.

Although it is virtually impossible to access the original version of this poetry (which was primarily transmitted orally), from the 16th century to the present day there have been efforts to transcribe, reconstruct, and partially translate numerous texts from pre-Columbian cultures. The relevance of these literary works is not only social—to acknowledge the cultural and political presence of Indigenous groups today—but also aesthetic and cultural: part of the current Latin American identity is influenced by this cultural heritage, and many 20th- and 21st-century writers have incorporated this heritage into their literary experimentation, such as Octavio Paz of Mexico (Nobel Prize 1992), Miguel Ángel Asturias of Guatemala (Nobel Prize 1967), José María Arguedas of Peru, and Elicura Chihuailaf of Chile, among many others.

Nahuatl poetry

“I have understood at last:
I hear a song; I see a flower:
oh, may they never wither!”

- Attributed to Nezahualcóyotl, ca. 1450

In Nahuatl, poetry was called “flower and song” (*in xochitl* , *in cuicatl*), a rich compound name that simultaneously described several aspects of poetic activity: a natural, visual, spontaneous, and expressive aesthetic of the sacred and of hope (the flower), and at the same time, an elaborate, collective, ritual, and musical one (the song) ^[1] . “Flower and song” consisted of a dialogue with one’s own heart, with the divine, with the world, and with the people, and it held great importance in Aztec society. Poets were princes or priests who represented the feelings of the community through words, music, and dance. For them, art was the way to imitate the divine creator, Ometéotl, a dual entity, father (Ometecuhtli) and mother (Omecíhuatl), also called Lord and Lady of the intimate and the near. Although the songs celebrated love, beauty, and heroism in war, among other themes, the fundamental objective of the poetry was to discuss the value of life: “only for a brief time are we borrowed from one another on Earth.” *Remembering* the ephemeral nature of life on Earth and affirming the possibility of transcendence and endurance are two essential goals of Nahuatl poetry.

^[1] Nahuatl is characterized by this type of double and metaphorical expression. Other examples are: “the face and the heart” = personality; “the black ink and the red ink” = wisdom; “to *carve* faces” = to educate.



"Nowhere can
the home of the supreme arbiter be;
everywhere he is invoked,
everywhere he is venerated.
Only by his side and beside him
can there be life on earth." ("Song to Ometéotl," by the poet Moyocatzín)

Left: Representation of Ometecuhtli and Omecíhuatl in the Borgia Codex. [Unknown author](#) , Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons

The songs and stories were memorized, but there were also large posters (the codices) with designs and phonetic symbols that the priest-poet indicated with his finger while reciting the corresponding poem. This choreographed activity was called "singing paintings," and it was presented as a mandatory spectacle for the people on special days.

These performances were of great social importance. For this reason, from the age of twelve, many young Aztecs of both sexes, if they did not dedicate themselves to war or agriculture, studied in a very rigorous institution for the teaching of poetry (music, language and dance) called the *cuicacalli* ("house of song").

Nahuatl poetry has very ancient roots, possibly dating back to the Olmec era (400 BC). However, most of the poems we know today were composed in the century before the Spanish conquest (15th century). Its most frequent imagery includes flowers—symbols of beauty, hope, and divine creation—precious stones—symbols of wealth and power—and birds, symbols of divine wisdom. Two basic stylistic elements were difrasismo (the expression of concepts through two more or less equivalent terms: "let us live in peace, in harmony") and parallelism (presenting two consecutive phrases that are repeated and complement each other: "let us go, we will look for flowers; let us go, we will cut flowers"). There were also compositions of various genres:

- The *Teotlatolli* dealt with the origins of the world and the divine universe.
- The *Teocuicatl* were hymns in honor of the gods.
- The *Xopancuicatl* were songs to life, to joy and to the beauty of the world.
- The *Xochicuicatl* were an exaltation of friendship and human nobility.
- The *Yaocuicatl* were warrior and heroic songs.
- The *Incocuicatl* expressed anguish, sadness, and reflection on death.

As an exercise, and while enjoying Nahuatl poetry, can you identify the genre of the following three fragments? What images or ideas do you find interesting and why? What characteristics of Nahuatl poetry are present in each fragment? (From *Anthology of Pre-Columbian Indigenous Poetry*, ed. Jorge Eduardo Paniagua).

Excerpt 1. Genre: _____

[**acaso**: tal vez - **colibrí**: *hummingbird*. - **esmeraldino**: color de esmeralda - **áureo**: color de oro - **corola**: el grupo de pétalos de una flor]

*I consult my own heart:
Where shall I find beautiful, fragrant flowers?
Whom shall I ask?
Shall I ask the shimmering green hummingbird,
the emerald-green flycatcher?
Shall I ask the golden butterfly?
Yes, they will know: they know where
the beautiful, fragrant flowers open their corollas.*

Excerpt 2. Genre: _____

[**mazorca**: el fruto del maíz - **azorarse**: confundirse o emocionarse - **mata**: planta - **primerizo**: primero, que comienza - **robustecerse**: hacerse fuerte]

*My God Mazorca, with his face held high,
is troubled for no reason.
I am the tender cornstalk:
from your mountains I come to see you, I am your God.
My life will be refreshed:
the firstborn man grows strong,
he who commands in war is born!*

Excerpt 3. Genre: _____

cual: como - **quetzal**: pájaro centroamericano de hermosas plumas verdes, sagrado entre los aztecas y mayas - **penacho**: ornamento de plumas - **plumas**: *feathers* - **préstamo**: *loan*

*Though we are united with each other in this world,
like quetzal feathers in a headdress,
though we are like stones on the same necklace,
.....
our life passes only once.
In a day we depart,
in a night we belong to the realm of the dead.
Alas, we have only come here to know each other,
we have only borrowed this earth.
Let us live thus in peace, let us live in harmony.*

Song of the women of Chalco

The “Song of the Women of Chalco” is attributed to the poet Aquiauhtzin, considered a wise man, who lived in the 15th century, before the arrival of the Spanish. Here are some excerpts. As you read them, can you consider what they reveal about gender

relations and eroticism? (from Mexican Songs, trans. Miguel León Portilla):

levantaos: <i>get up!</i> se extienden: <i>spread around</i> escudo: <i>shield</i> se antojan a los hombres: <i>are desired by men</i>	Rise up, my little sisters, let us go, let us go, we will seek flowers, let us go, let us go, we will cut flowers. Here they spread, here they spread the flowers of water and fire, the flowers of the shield, those that men crave, those that give prestige: those of war.
anhelo: <i>longing</i> hilar: <i>to thread, to spin</i>	They are beautiful flowers, with the flowers that are upon me I adorn myself, they are my flowers, I am from Chalco, I am a woman! I desire and desire the flowers, I desire and desire the songs. I am longingly here in the place where we spin, in the place where our life goes.
entonar: <i>to intone</i> entretener: <i>to entwine</i> circundar: <i>to surround,</i> <i>rodear</i> lecho: <i>bed</i>	I sing his song to the lord, little Axayácatl. I weave it with flowers, I surround it with them. Like a painting is the beautiful song, like fragrant flowers that bring joy, my heart cherishes them on earth. So too I cherish your word, companion in bed, you, little Axayácatl. I weave it with flowers, I surround it with flowers. Thus I will give pleasure to my companion in bed.
haz que se yerga lo que me hace mujer: <i>have what</i> <i>makes me a woman rise</i> de veras: <i>truly</i> encenderse: <i>to fire up</i> deleite: <i>delight</i> desflorar: <i>ejaculate,</i> <i>penetrate</i> mamar: <i>breast-feed</i>	Companion, little companion, Mr. Axayácatl. Let what makes me a woman rise up, let much truth ignite. We will laugh, we will rejoice, there will be delight, I will have glory. But no, don't deflower me yet, My friend, you, my lord, little Axayácatl. You want to suckle at my breasts, almost at my heart
acomódate: <i>get comfortable</i> acaso: <i>by any chance</i> lograr: <i>to accomplish</i>	My companion, my little boy, let's be together, settle down by my side, let your manly self speak. Don't I know, don't I have any experience of your enemies, my little boy? But now surrender yourself to my side. Even though we are women, perhaps you will achieve nothing as a man.
revuélveme: <i>stir me</i> por completo: <i>completamente</i> estera: <i>mat</i> entregate: <i>give yourself</i>	Flowers and songs of the companion of pleasure, you, lord, companion, my little boy, stir me like corn dough. I offer myself to you completely. I have come to give pleasure to my flowery vulva, my small mouth.

I desire the lord, the little Axayácatl.
Look at my flowery painting, my breasts,
let us have pleasure on your mat of flowers.
And where you exist, little companion,
little by little surrender to sleep,
be at peace, my little boy,
you, lord Axayácatl.

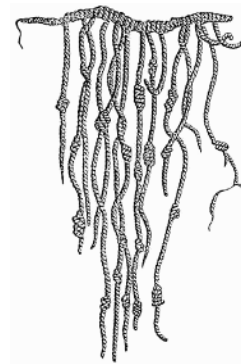
Quechua Poetry

The official language of the Incas and the peoples belonging to their empire was Quechua (from *qishwa* , "temperate zone"), also called Runasimi (*runa* : people, *simi* : speech, mouth). This culture, like the Aztec, also placed great importance on poetry, which was present in all social activities: agriculture, funerals, official ceremonies, and love. However, unlike the Nahuatl codices, the Incas did not have a known writing system, so there is no clear documentation of their original literature.

The only system of signs known to date is that of the *quipus* , which were cords with knots of colors and shapes distributed in such a way that they could be "read" to record historical information, numbers, etc. Thus, the only documents we have today about Quechua poetry come from colonial chronicles, for example, those of Felipe Guamán Poma de Ayala, Father Cristóbal de Molina, or Inca Garcilaso de la Vega.

Left: Inca Quipu.

[Unknown author](#)[Unknown author](#) , Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons



According to accounts recorded by chroniclers, Inca nobles also received a rigorous literary education at an institution called the *Yachayhuasi* . There, they were taught by *amautas* , historians and philosophers who also created historical, epic, and sacred poetry. Finally, the *haravicus* , or "inventors of poetry," were specialists in the art of language and music. The *haravicus* did not necessarily belong to the noble class, and they not only contributed to embellishing epic or sacred poems, but also composed other types of more lyrical, personal, or popular poetry. Among the poetic genres of the Incas were: the *Jailli* , a sacred hymn to the gods, heroism, and agricultural tasks; the *Arawi* , intimate, amorous, or melancholic poetry; the *Wawaki* , a dialogue poem between the sexes; the *Qhashwa* , a song of dance and joy; and the *Wayñu* , a collective poem that included dance and music.

As an exercise, and while enjoying Inca poetry, can you identify the genre of the following three fragments? What images or ideas do you find interesting and why? What characteristics of Inca poetry are present in each fragment? What similarities and differences do you find with the Nahuatl poetic style? (From *Anthology of Pre-Columbian Indigenous Poetry* , ed. Jorge Eduardo Paniagua).

Fragment 1. Genre: _____ (Transcribed by Guamán Poma, 1615)

[entre tanto: *meanwhile* - "tuya": extracción de una semilla. - paloma: *dove* - prado: *meadow*]

*The time will come to bring joy to our Inca.
We will dance with him under the full moon.
We will sing the sweetest song.
The time will come to dance with our Inca.
Meanwhile, my darling , my golden dove,
do not fear the full moon.
Let us meet in the flowery meadow
to play beneath the golden star.*

Fragment 2. Genre: _____ (Transcribed by Molina, 1575)

[**Viracocha**: Creador, Dios supremo de los incas. - **el ser**: *the being* - **con solo**: *just by* - **sea**: *may it be (command)* - **que viva**: *may I live (request)*]

*Cause of being, Viracocha,
ever-present God,
Judge who is in all,
God who governs and provides,
Who creates simply by saying:
“Let there be man, let there be woman.”
May the being you placed and nurtured live free and in peace.
Where are you?
Outside or inside?
In the cloud or in the shadow?*

Fragment 3. Genre: _____ (Transcribed by Guamán Poma, 1615)

[**tierno**: *tender* - **manjar**: *comida deliciosa* - **lágrima**: *tear* - **arrastrar**: *drag* - **empujar**: *push*]

*My dark-haired beauty, my dark-haired beauty,
tender delicacy, smile of the water,
your heart knows no sorrows
and your eyes know no tears.*

*Because you are the most beautiful woman,
because you are my queen,
because you are my princess,
I let the water of love
carry me away in its current,
I let the storm
of passion push me.*

A Wawaki

The following is an example of *Wawaki*, which was sung by two choirs, one of men and one of women. As you read, think about how gender roles are defined and understood in this poem:

fulgurar: <i>to shine, brillar</i>	The princes Because you are a star, yes! You shine at night, yes! For under the fire of the sun, yes! I seek you in vain. Yes!
entornar los ojos: <i>half-close one's eyes</i>	The princesses. If I am a star, no! Open your heart, no! And under the fire of the sun, no! Close your eyes. No!
simular: <i>to pretend</i> acercarse: <i>to get close</i> trocar: <i>to change into</i>	The princes. Only by moonlight, yes! You pretend to call me, yes! And when I approach, yes! You turn into snow. Yes!
presuroso acude: <i>please rush to respond</i> echar: <i>to pour into</i>	The princesses. And if I pretend to call you, no! Come quickly. No! If I turn into snow, no! Throw your fire on me. No!

The rich poetic production of Indigenous peoples is part of Latin American cultural tradition, not only as history but also as a source of contemporary creativity. Famous poets of the 20th and 21st centuries have incorporated this tradition into their literary work. Furthermore, Indigenous cultures today continue to develop their collective experience through poetry, literature, and art in general.

Review questions

1. What language did the Aztecs speak? In what region did they live?
2. What language did the Incas speak? In what region did they live?
3. What was the name of poetry in Nahuatl? What ideas does this name evoke?
4. What was the fundamental purpose of Nahuatl poetry? Give an example.
5. What was the social importance of Nahuatl poetry? How was it disseminated?
6. What are some characteristics of the style and imagery of Nahuatl poetry?
7. What was the social importance of Quechua poetry? How was it disseminated?
8. What was an *amauta*? What was a *haravicus*?
9. What are some characteristics of the style and imagery of Quechua poetry?

▮ [Más poemas en: Muestra de poesía en náhuatl y en quechua.](#)

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6.17: Literary Tendencies

In this section you will learn about some of the literary movements that have influenced 20th century Mexican-American poetry, including the avant-garde movement (*el movimiento vanguardista*), the Chicano nationalist movement, and the importance of bilingual texts for the Chicano community.

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6.18: Movimientos vanguardistas



(Translated from Spanish)

During the first half of the 20th century in Latin America, a significant portion of artistic production reflected the impact of social activism and the profound ideological shifts that occurred in the Western world during those years. These movements, parallel to their European counterparts, were grouped under the generic term " **avant - garde** ", " sharing characteristics with what is known in the English-speaking world as *Modernism* in the field of aesthetics.

The painting on the left illustrates the rich development of avant-garde aesthetics in Latin America. With surrealist elements that draw on the symbolism of the unconscious, dreams, and ancestral heritage, it depicts the complex relationship between social classes, cultural roots, and visions of personal and collective identity that characterized the experimentation of avant-garde movements, in dialogue with innovations from diverse geographies, fields of knowledge, and historical sources.



"The Two Fridas" (1939), by Frida Kahlo (Mexico 1907-1954).

Ideological-political context

materias primas: raw materials
obrero: industry worker
apoyo: support
fortalecimiento: strengthening
huelga: strike
así como: as well as

As we have seen (§5.1), the 20th century began in many Latin American countries with an economic expansion driven by the export of raw materials. This generated considerable urban growth and an increase in the size of the middle and working classes. Some sectors of the merchant elite favored political reforms to gain the support of a broader segment of the population. On the other hand, worker and peasant activism had a particularly strong influence, not only because it was connected to the global strengthening of leftist movements, but also because any strike that affected export infrastructure had a crucial impact on the economies of Latin American countries. Thus, labor mobilization fostered processes of redefining national identity. The debates and initiatives put forward by the working classes, as well as the impression that the European model was not necessarily superior, increased interest in local demonstrations and alternative visions for the future of these nations.

This redefinition of national identities and the arts was partly a response to the changes that Western Europe underwent in the first decades of the 20th century. Until the end of the 19th century, Western culture imagined itself as a superior civilizing force for progress and social harmony, with technological advances transforming transportation, communication, and mass production. But the horrors of the First World War (1914-18) dealt a major blow to this positivist vision and generated distrust of science and rationalism. Even before this, especially with Karl Marx (1818-1883), the principles of capitalism and bourgeois society were being strongly questioned. Scholars of consciousness like Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) challenged the dominance of reason (the Enlightenment idea that man was a rational animal) and emphasized the importance of other aspects of the psyche, which the father of psychoanalysis demonstrated in dreams and the erotic aspects of the unconscious, as in his book *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900). In 1905 and 1915, Albert Einstein (1879-1955) published his theories of relativity, which integrated time with the three dimensions of space, generating a complete revision of how reality was conceived. Meanwhile, *The Decline of the West* (1918-22), a work by the German philosopher Oswald Spengler (1880-1936), postulated the aging of European civilization

and its need to renew itself through contact with other cultures. The nightmare of the First World War confirmed these theories and also called into question the value of expansionist, colonialist, or imperial projects. All of this contributed to a radical self-examination of Western culture and the arts.

In connection with workers' activism and this cultural re-evaluation, certain values became prevalent in the intellectual and urban world: "being at the forefront," innovating, protesting, fighting for rights, issuing manifestos, breaking with tradition, being cosmopolitan, and challenging bourgeois comfort. Artistic production visibly reflected this impact through movements grouped under the generic name of " **the Avant-garde** , " an appropriately military and militant term that became fashionable in France to indicate this combative desire to be at the forefront of change and participate in social transformation.

Many groups of artists and poets drafted their manifestos or organized themselves into movements. Famous in Europe were Fauvism (1905), Cubism (1907), Futurism (1909), Dadaism (1916), and Surrealism (1924). Each of these "-isms" defined its own aesthetic priorities, but all were driven by the enthusiasm to propose new expressive possibilities that would keep pace with the rapid rhythm of sociocultural change. The following predominated in avant-garde aesthetics:

- experimentation with forms and expressive possibilities (breaking rules, playful sense);
- a level of activism or emancipation against the traditional or conventional;
- self-definition: each movement produces its own definition of "what is art";
- questioning of the "self" as a unit and of authority as something just or desirable;
- and an inquiry into the processes of representation:
- They seek to affect and "shock" the public (reader, spectator), they are anti-sentimental;
 - to show how the medium (words, painting, etc.) influences what is represented, and
 - to show how social relationships influence what is acceptable, beautiful, or artistic.

Four European avant-garde movements that had widespread dissemination in Latin America were:

Cubism . In its analytical phase (1907-12), Cubism sought to depict the object from diverse perspectives, exploring the limits of realism by fragmenting and recomposing the image with paintings dominated by a geometric vision. In its synthetic phase (1913-30), forms were simplified; more vibrant colors were used, and the recreated object became more abstract. A famous exponent of Cubism was the Spaniard Pablo Picasso (1881-1973), formerly a member of the Fauvist group. [1]

Futurism. In 1909, the "Futurist Manifesto" appeared in Italy, mimicking political activism to defend an artistic movement against traditionalism and in celebration of modernization, speed, technology, violence, youth, and industry. It was a movement in literature and the visual arts launched by Filippo Tommaso Marinetti (1876-1944). It sought to portray the dynamic character of the 20th century by glorifying war, danger, and machines. In literature, it championed free imagination, the breaking of syntax, the subversion of punctuation, the use of inks of various colors, and the disordered arrangement of letters, words, and verses. In 1918, the "Futurist Political Party" joined Mussolini's fascism.

Expressionism. From the early years of the 20th century, several German and Northern European artists sought to represent the pain and violence before and after the world wars, exploring subjective perception to evoke ideas and moods and to innovate in creative possibilities. Their aesthetic emphasizes individual freedom, emotional expression, irrationalism, and shocking or taboo themes such as the morbid, demonic, fantastical, or sexual. In several of these characteristics, it resembles French Fauvism [1] .

Surrealism . As a movement, it was founded with a manifesto promoted in 1924 by the Frenchman André Breton (1896-1966). The name comes from a work by the poet Guillaume Apollinaire (1880-1918), a staunch critic of World War II, which he subtitled "surrealist drama" (*Les Mamelles de Tiresias*, 1917). Influenced by the discoveries of psychoanalysis, the Surrealists were particularly interested in free association, dreams, inner life, alternative understandings of reality, and the mythological perception of the world (archetypes). The Spanish painters Salvador Dalí (1904-1989) and Joan Miró (1893-1983), and the director Luis Buñuel (1900-1983), are some of its most influential representatives. In Latin America, Surrealism developed its own distinct character, enriched by indigenous and African cultural sources. In the paintings of Cuban Wilfredo Lam (1902-1982) and Mexican Frida Kahlo (1907-1954), one finds this type of Latin American or "postcolonial" surrealism which, by taking the implications of the European movement further, breaks with it and affirms the creative force of previously undervalued cultural sources.

Of all these movements, the one that had the most lasting impact on 20th-century literature in general, and on the Hispanic world in particular, was Surrealism. This is partly explained by its less restrictive formal tenets: it is more interested in investigating a type of experience than in imposing a specific mode of representing it. Its aesthetic also articulates the three basic critiques of modern societies: 1) social injustice and violence; 2) rationalism; and 3) Eurocentrism or colonialism. Furthermore, it explores the aspects of human experience most relevant to artistic and literary production as understood in the contemporary era: subjectivity, consciousness, and identity. Most influential is its conception of the work, not as an expression of emotions or the rational authorial self, but as a space for experimentation and discovery, in which other forces manifest themselves (the unconscious, cultural archetypes, the mechanics of language). Among the many names that could be mentioned in the development of Latin American surrealism, the Cuban painter Wilfredo Lam (1902-1982), the Guatemalan novelist Miguel Ángel Asturias (1899-1974), the Chilean writer María Luisa Bombal (1910-1980), and the Mexican painters Frida Kahlo (1907-1954) and Rufino Tamayo (1899-1991) stand out. The latter is also associated with the expressionist aesthetic, which was championed by artists such as Débora Arango (Colombia 1907-2005) and Oswaldo Guayasamín (Ecuador 1919-1999), among many others.

 Detalle del mural de Oswaldo Guayasamín (Palacio Legislativo, Quito) 001

Detail of a mural by Ecuadorian artist Oswaldo Guayasamín, an example of the muralist art movement that developed from the 1920s onward, following the Mexican Revolution, and spread throughout Latin America with a mixed, avant-garde aesthetic.

[H3kt0r](#), [CC BY-SA 4.0](#), via Wikimedia Commons

[1] Fauvism (1905) emphasized emotional intensity through the distortion of forms and the dissonant use of colors. Its most prominent exponent was Henri Matisse (1869-1954).

Avant-garde Hispanic American poetry

The poetics immediately following Modernism can be grouped into two directions. The first, known as **Latin American postmodernism**, **emphasizes** *formal* imagerysimplification with a localist spirit; the second, of an avant-garde type, **radicalizes** the exploration of the critical place of art in modern societies with intense formal *experimentation* and a cosmopolitan spirit.

Much of the Latin American intelligentsia participated in the process of aesthetic and cultural self-revision that took place in the West during the first half of the 20th century. For example, the renewal fervor in Spain during the Second Republic (1931-39) was fueled by important Latin American poets such as Pablo Neruda and César Vallejo. To give another example, Mexican Surrealism was as vibrant as its Parisian counterpart, with world-renowned figures like the painter Frida Kahlo, the filmmaker Luis Buñuel (who lived in Mexico from 1949), and the poet Octavio Paz (1914-1998). While journals were created to disseminate these ideas, numerous manifestos were written and published to defend them. In most cases, however, the norms of the “-isms” were not strictly followed, but rather their innovative and experimental spirit was adopted to break conventional molds and open fruitful paths to poetry: the importance of studying non-European art, which had been promoted by Cubists and Fauvists, the introduction of technological language, which was defended by the Futurists, and the revolutionary or liberating value of non-conscious creativity, which was invigorated by the Surrealists, among other directions.

In 1914, the Chilean poet Vicente Huidobro presented his poetic manifesto “ *Non serviam* ” in Santiago, where he laid the foundations for the movement he later called **Creationism** , which conceived of poetry as the creation of reality, not as its representation. His proposals became more radical when, with avant-garde artists from Paris, he collaborated on the magazine *Nord -Sud* (1917-18). Works from this period, such as “Paisaje” (Landscape), experiment with the visual dimension of the poem to expand its possibilities for representation and the suggestion of multiple meanings.

Paysage [de Horizon Carré, 1917]



Paisaje

AL ATARDECER NOS PASEAREMOS POR RUTAS PARALELAS

La Luna
es
donde
mira

EL ÁRBOL
ERA
MÁS
ALTO
QUE LA
MONTAÑA

PERO LA
MONTAÑA
ERA TAN ANCHA
QUE EXCEDÍA
LOS EXTREMOS
DE LA TIERRA

EL
RÍO
QUE
CORRE
NO
LLEVA
PECES

CUIDADO CON
JUGAR EN EL PASTO
RECIÉN PINTADO

UNA CANCIÓN CONDUCE A LAS OVEJAS HACIA EL APRISCO

VICENTE HUIDOBRO

In 1918, in Madrid, Huidobro helped found **Ultraism**, a movement also joined by the Argentinian Jorge Luis Borges (1899-1986), who was living in Spain at the time. Upon returning to Argentina, Borges and other young writers disseminated Ultraism with the premise of eliminating (modernist) ornamentation and reducing poetry to its fundamental elements: imagery, typography, and linguistic innovation. The movement also sought to capture modernization through neologisms, references to technological advances, parody, and the incorporation of regional experiences. Borges later abandoned this aesthetic in favor of philosophical meditation and dialogue with universal culture.

Latin American avant-garde movements spread primarily through literary journals that fostered debate and celebrated striking innovation. In Argentina, notable publications included *Prisma* (1921), *Proa* (1922-25), *Martín Fierro* (1924-27), and, a few years later, *Sur*, founded by the writer Victoria Ocampo (1890-1979); in Cuba, *Revista de Avance* (1927-30); and in Peru, *Amauta* (1926-30), founded by the Marxist and indigenist thinker José Carlos Mariátegui (1894-1930). Around this time, **Stridentism** also emerged in Mexico (c. 1922), with an aesthetic influenced by Futurism, whose most prominent exponent was the poet Manuel Maples Arce (1898-1981). Shortly afterward, the "Contemporáneos" group formed, centered around two important journals: *Ulises* (1927-28) and *Contemporáneos* (1928-31). Among them were Carlos Pellicer (1897-1977), José Gorostiza (1901-73), Jaime Torres Bodet (1902-74), Xavier Villaurrutia (1903-50), and Salvador Novo (1904-1974), several of whom were also playwrights. This group embraced the avant-garde impulse, proposing thought-provoking directions for the dialogue between poetry, the other arts, the psyche, and society.

In the early stages of avant-garde poetry in Latin America, the Mexican modernist José Juan Tablada (1871-1945) stands out, having introduced the plasticity of the Japanese haiku; the Argentinians Silvina Ocampo (1903-1993), Norah Lange (1905-1972), and Oliverio Girondo (1891-1967), who explored cubist concepts and surrealist possibilities in a cosmopolitan and self-aware poetry; Vicente Huidobro (1893-1948), the theorist and most constant defender of creationism, visual poems, and the radical search—for life and aesthetics—that avant-garde movements represent worldwide; and the Peruvian César Vallejo (1892-1938), whose varied work, which connects avant-garde combativeness with the aspirations of the proletariat in a profoundly personal and

suggestive way, continues to have a deep influence on Latin American (and world) poetic production to this day. The [Negrista](#) and [Indigenista](#) movements also incorporate avant-garde aesthetics into their proposals.

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6.19: Mexican-American Essayists

In this final chapter, we will turn to the genre of the literary essay. In this section you will read essays by some of the most influential writers of the Mexican-American essay, including Rudolfo Anaya and Gloria Anzaldúa.

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6.20: Rudolfo Anaya

"Best known for his novel *Bless Me, Ultima*, which established him as one of the founders of Chicano literature, Rudolfo Anaya displays his gift for storytelling and deep connection to the land and its history in *The Essays*. These intimate and contemplative essays explore censorship, immigration, urban development, the Southwest as a region, and personal identity." - Open Road Media
From the Introduction to *The Essays* by Rudolfo Anaya.

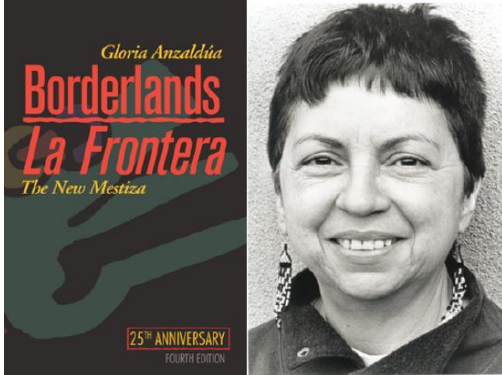
In the attached excerpt, you will find his essays on machismo, as well as the mythological *La Llorona*.

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6.21: Gloria Anzaldúa

"Gloria E. Anzaldúa was a queer Chicana poet, writer, and feminist theorist...Her book *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza* (1987) and her essay "La Prieta" are considered groundbreaking works in cultural, feminist, and queer theories." Source: [Poetry Foundation](#)

Read an excerpt from *Borderlands/La Frontera* here [\[Website\]](#).



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6.22: Sergio Troncoso

The following essay is the Introduction from [*"Nepantla Familias: An Anthology of Mexican American Literature on Families in Between Worlds"*](#) (Texas A&M University Press), a collection of essays, short stories, and poems edited by award-winning author and scholar Sergio Troncoso, who was born in El Paso and raised in Ysleta. "Nepantla Familias" includes the work of acclaimed Mexican American writers and emerging voices, including El Paso's own Daniel Chacon, Sheryl Luna, David Dorado Romo, and Octavio Solis.

[Read the essay here \[Website\]](#).



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6.23: Sandra Cisneros

Only Daughter by Sandra Cisneros

From *Latina: Women's Voices From the Borderlands*. Edited by Lillian Castillo-Speed. New York: Touchstone/Simon & Schuster, 1995.

Once, several years ago, when I was just starting out my writing career, I was asked to write my own contributor's note for an anthology I was part of. I wrote: "I am the only daughter in a family of six sons. That explains everything."

Well, I've thought about that ever since, and yes, it explains a lot to me, but for the reader's sake I should have written: "I am the only daughter in a Mexican family of six sons." Or even: "I am the only daughter of a Mexican father and a Mexican-American mother." Or: "I am the only daughter of a working-class family of nine." All of these had everything to do with who I am today.

I was/am the only daughter and only a daughter. Being an only daughter in a family of six sons forced me by circumstance to spend a lot of time by myself because my brothers felt it beneath them to play with a girl in public. But that aloneness, that loneliness, was good for a would-be writer—it allowed me time to think and think, to imagine, to read and prepare myself.

Being only a daughter for my father meant my destiny would lead me to become someone's wife. That's what he believed. But when I was in the fifth grade and shared my plans for college with him, I was sure he understood. I remember my father saying, "Que bueno, mi'ha, that's good." That meant a lot to me, especially since my brothers thought the idea hilarious. What I didn't realize was that my father thought college was good for girls—good for finding a husband. After four years in college and two more in graduate school, and still no husband, my father shakes his head even now and says I wasted all that education.

In retrospect, I'm lucky my father believed daughters were meant for husbands. It meant it didn't matter if I majored in something silly like English. After all, I'd find a nice professional eventually, right? This allowed me the liberty to putter about embroidering my little poems and stories without my father interrupting with so much as a "What's that you're writing?"

But the truth is, I wanted him to interrupt. I wanted my father to understand what it was I was scribbling, to introduce me as "My only daughter, the writer." Not as "This is only my daughter. She teaches." Es maestra—teacher. Not even profesora.

In a sense, everything I have ever written has been for him, to win his approval even though I know my father can't read English words, even though my father's only reading includes the brown-ink *Esto* sports magazines from Mexico City and the bloody *¡Alarma!* magazines that feature yet another sighting of La Virgen de Guadalupe on a tortilla or a wife's revenge on her philandering husband by bashing his skull in with a molcajete (a kitchen mortar made of volcanic rock). Or the fotonovelas, the little picture paperbacks with tragedy and trauma erupting from the characters' mouths in bubbles.

My father represents, then, the public majority. A public who is disinterested in reading, and yet one whom I am writing about and for, and privately trying to woo.

When we were growing up in Chicago, we moved a lot because of my father. He suffered bouts of nostalgia. Then we'd have to let go of our flat, store the furniture with mother's relatives, load the station wagon with baggage and bologna sandwiches and head south. To Mexico City.

We came back, of course. To yet another Chicago flat, another Chicago neighborhood, another Catholic school. Each time, my father would seek out the parish priest in order to get a tuition break, and complain or boast: "I have seven sons."

He meant *siete hijos*, seven children, but he translated it as "sons." "I have seven sons." To anyone who would listen. The Sears Roebuck employee who sold us the washing machine. The short-order cook where my father ate his ham-and-eggs breakfasts. "I have seven sons." As if he deserved a medal from the state.

My papa. He didn't mean anything by that mistranslation, I'm sure. But somehow I could feel myself being erased. I'd tug my father's sleeve and whisper: "Not seven sons. Six! and one daughter."

When my oldest brother graduated from medical school, he fulfilled my father's dream that we study hard and use this—our heads, instead of this—our hands. Even now my father's hands are thick and yellow, stubbed by a history of hammer and nails and twine and coils and springs. "Use this," my father said, tapping his head, "and not this," showing us those hands. He always looked tired when he said it.

Wasn't college an investment? And hadn't I spent all those years in college? And if I didn't marry, what was it all for? Why would anyone go to college and then choose to be poor? Especially someone who had always been poor.

Last year, after ten years of writing professionally, the financial rewards started to trickle in. My second National Endowment for the Arts Fellowship. A guest professorship at the University of California, Berkeley. My book, which sold to a major New York publishing house.

At Christmas, I flew home to Chicago. The house was throbbing, same as always: hot tamales and sweet tamales hissing in my mother's pressure cooker, and everybody—my mother, six brothers, wives, babies, aunts, cousins—talking too loud and at the same time. Like in a Fellini film, because that's just how we are.

I went upstairs to my father's room. One of my stories had just been translated into Spanish and published in an anthology of Chicano writing and I wanted to show it to him. Ever since he recovered from a stroke two years ago, my father likes to spend his leisure hours horizontally. And that's how I found him, watching a Pedro Infante movie on Galavisión and eating rice pudding.

There was a glass filled with milk on the bedside table. There were several vials of pills and balled Kleenex. And on the floor, one black sock and a plastic urinal that I didn't want to look at but looked at anyway. Pedro Infante was about to burst into song, and my father was laughing.

I'm not sure if it was because my story was translated into Spanish, or because it was published in Mexico, or perhaps because the story dealt with Tepeyac, the colonia my father was raised in and the house he grew up in, but at any rate, my father punched the mute button on his remote control and read my story.

I sat on the bed next to my father and waited. He read it very slowly. As if he were reading each line over and over. He laughed at all the right places and read lines he liked out loud. He pointed and asked questions: "Is this So-and-so?" "Yes," I said. He kept reading.

When he was finally finished, after what seemed like hours, my father looked up and asked: "Where can we get more copies of this for the relatives?"

Of all the wonderful things that happened to me last year, that was the most wonderful.

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Francisco X. Alarcón

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